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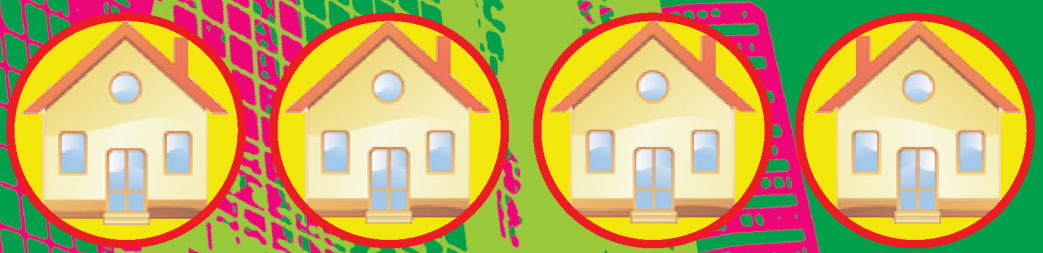
LIVING & WORK LITERACY 7

MOVING OUT



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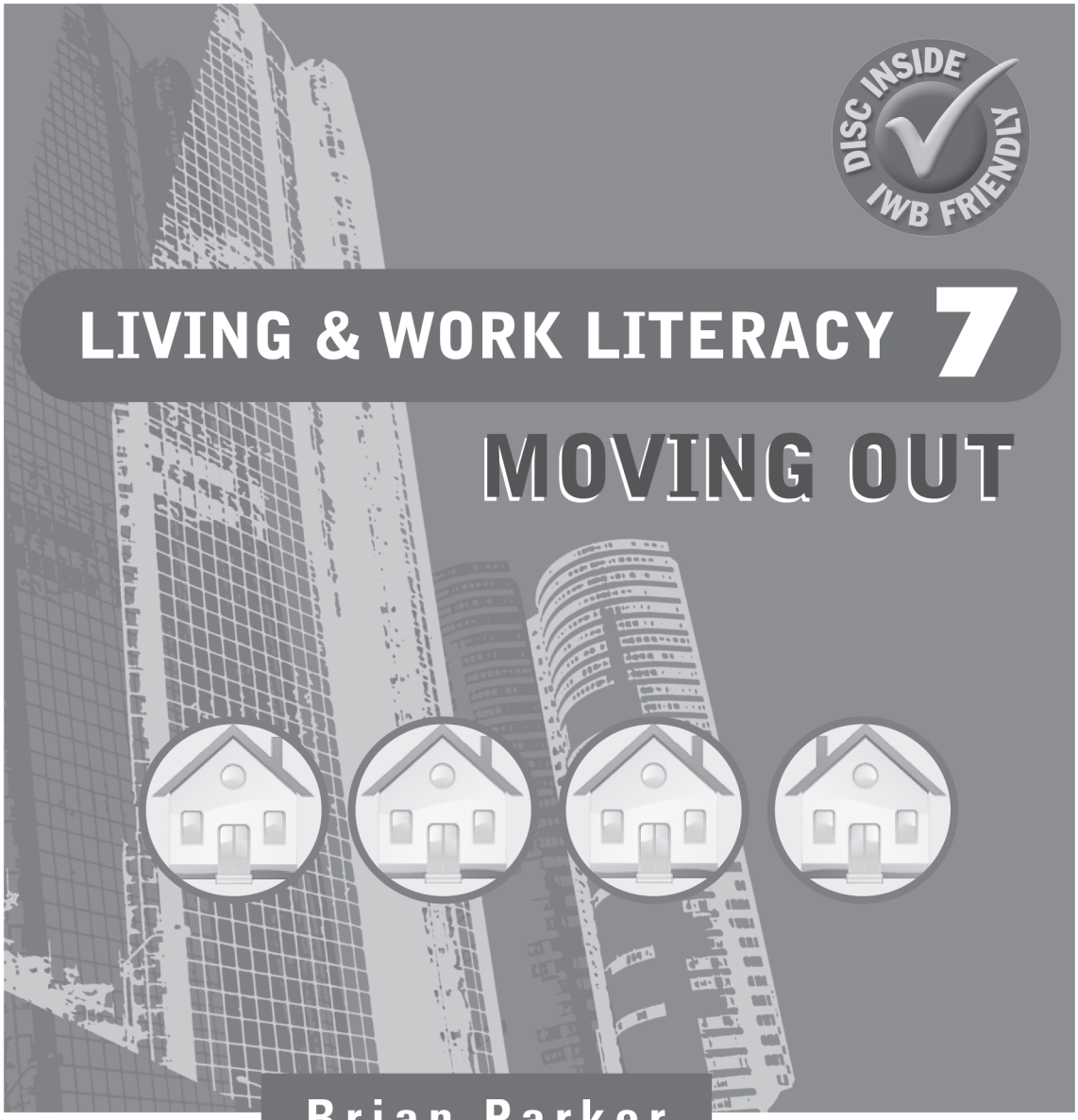

LIVING & WORK LITERACY 7

MOVING OUT

Brian Parker

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Introduction

The photocopiable activities in this title explore some of the practical issues for young adults as they move towards independent living. Working through the units, students consider the reasons why young adults move out of the family home, finding a place to live, different housing options, signing a lease and the issues involved in shared living. Concepts are reinforced through a range of challenging short answer, class discussion and research activities.

Topics contained in this book are suitable for secondary school subjects in years 7–10 that teach young people about the practical skills and knowledge that they need to participate fully in society. All the worksheets are included as a PDF on the attached CD-ROM, making them ideal resources for use on interactive whiteboards.

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1 When can I leave home?

Scenario – two students having a conversation in the living room at Ben's place

Ben: I'm sick of living at home. I'm always fighting with my parents – I can't wait to get out of here.

Jessica: I'm thinking of moving out too, but not because I fight with my folks.

Ben: What do you mean? Do you get along well with your parents?

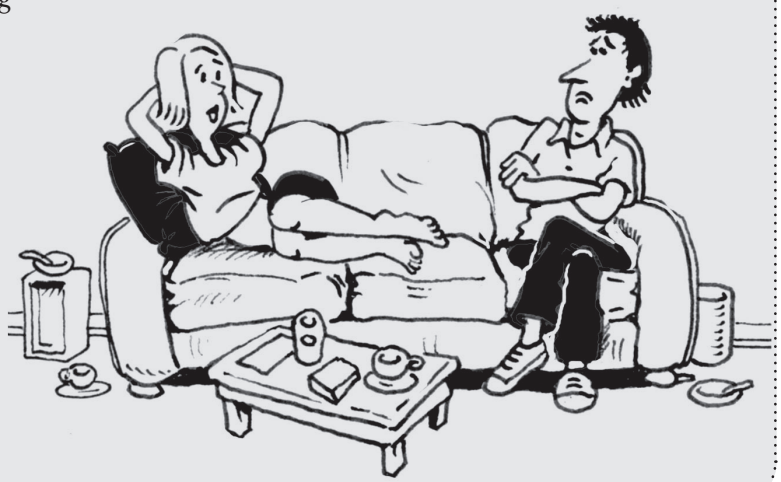
Jessica: Yep, always have. They're great – that's not why I want to move out. I just want some more independence and some freedom.

Ben: Yeah, I just want to be able to do what I like.

Jessica: I think there's more to it than that. You have responsibilities.

Ben: Like what?

Jessica: Oh, it's late! I'll tell you later – I have to get home!



Moving out of home is a big step. Different people have different ideas about how it will work, and when they are ready to do it. Ben and Jessica, in the above scenario, illustrate just a couple of these different viewpoints. It is natural for teenagers to want their independence, and many see moving out as a way to achieve this. In some cases the process is negotiated mutually between the person and their parents or guardians, while in other cases there may be disagreement or conflict. Whatever the situation, there are some important legal points to consider.

What the law says

- When you turn 18 you can legally leave home. If you are under 18 you are classified as a 'minor'. Turning 18 means you achieve your 'majority'.
- If you are under 18 years of age, you can still leave home under the following circumstances:
  - if your parents or carers agree to you leaving home, despite your age
  - if your safety and well-being is under threat in your home environment
  - if you have left school and wish to attend an educational institution (such as a TAFE college) that is located too far from home for you to be able to attend on a daily basis
  - if you have left school and have found a job located a long way from your home.
- At age 18 you can also enter into loan contracts, sign a lease for accommodation and make major purchases (such as a car or motorbike).

Things to consider before moving out

Moving out of home is a big step. It is important to consider the decision carefully and not rush into anything. Teenagers who are considering moving out may not be fully aware of the responsibilities that come with living out of home. They may not be prepared to manage their finances independently, or they may not be ready to handle living in a shared environment with people they don't necessarily know very well.

Similarly, their parents may worry about who they will be living with, or how they might cope without the daily support of their family. Some parents may prefer their children to live at home until they get married.

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Tips for making the decision

Moving out can be a positive and even life-changing experience. These useful tips might help in the decision:

- Think it through – make sure you've really thought about whether you're ready. Don't act too hastily. Can you afford to move out? Is it the right time or are you rushing into it?
- Communicate effectively – discuss your decision with your parents and friends as well as potential flatmates.
- Don't be afraid to ask for help if you feel you need it – if you encounter difficulties there are other people willing to help you.

Activities

1 Read the scenario on the previous page and think about how Ben and Jessica's parents might feel about their situations. Write conversations between:

- ***a*** Ben's parents, Graham and Betty, discussing their son's behaviour and attitude
- ***b*** Jessica's parents, Bill and Adele, discussing their daughter's approach to moving out.

2 When can you legally leave home? Why?

3 Under what circumstances could you leave home before this?

4 Why might some teenagers be worried about leaving home?

5 Why might parents also worry when their child leaves home?

6 After talking to Jessica, Ben had a huge fight with his parents. He decided to leave home straight away. Do you think Ben made the right decision? Which of the tips listed above did Ben fail to heed?

7 What do you think Jessica would have said to Ben if she didn't have to rush home?

8 What skills do you think you need if you are moving out? Why do you need them and who is likely to be involved?

9 Alicia left school and was offered a job in a restaurant quite a distance from her parents' home. She was faced with either accepting the job and moving out, or rejecting the job offer. What factors do you think Alicia should consider in making her decision? If you were Alicia, what would you do? Why?

10 Omar was in his final year at school and wanted to study law at a university. He had applied to study at a university close to home and one in another state. What factors would Omar need to consider:

- ***a*** if he was accepted into both universities
- ***b*** if he failed to gain entry to the university close to home?

In groups, discuss the advantages and disadvantages of leaving home before you are 18 years old. Consider things like rights and responsibilities. Record a summary of the discussion on a poster or display board.

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2 Moving out, moving back

Not everyone wants to move out of home immediately – in fact, some people are moving back. Read the following newspaper article about a recent trend in society.

Life lessons lost for the stay-at-home generation

JUDITH IRELAND
January 9, 2010

Kippers, boomerang kids, rent-free adults or freeloading lazy bums.

Whatever the latest market research term, it's become increasingly common for young people to live with their parents rather than spring off on their own.

Recent Australian Bureau of Statistics analysis indicates that young Australians are staying at home more than ever before. An estimated 23 per cent of 20- to 34-year-olds are living in their parental home. And almost half of those who leave before their mid-30s end up rebounding back to their old bedrooms at least once over the next few years.

The Pew Research Centre recently found rising numbers of US graduates are returning to the family bosom, while the British Business and Skills Secretary, Lord Mandelson, has called on parents to be more forceful when ousting their little kippers (kids in parents' pockets eroding retirement savings).

Naturally, the reasons behind the trend are more complex than just laziness or an undying love of mum's lasagne. People marrying later, coupled with huge increases in tertiary study, the sky-high cost of housing and frosty economic climes are just some of the factors that have conspired to make it less necessary and more expensive to move out.

Yet for a significant proportion of young people there is also an element of choice in the matter. Those with full-time jobs in their 20s and even their 30s are staying put to save money for entertainment or investments rather than ''waste" it on rent. As 26-year-old labourer, Joe Singleton, who lives with his parents, recently told Britain's *Sun*, "I could probably afford to live elsewhere if I didn't go out but I want to buy rather than rent."

According to the ABS, the most common reasons for young Australians to stay at home are money issues along with convenience and enjoyment.

While the financial costs of moving out are widely recognised, the social costs of bunking down in the 'burbs until the economy picks up or some babe pops the question are barely mentioned.

Share housing may still be the most common living arrangement for people in their early 20s but an increasing number are missing out on the experience. Unglorified by frat houses, *Big Brother* and John Birmingham's horror tale, *He Died with a Felafel in his Hand*, the share house is also an important staging ground between childhood reliance on your family and something approaching adult independence, be it on your own or with someone you really love. Even your basic-model share house – with its inbuilt compromises, simmering disagreements, snarky estate agents and propensity for things to break - has the potential to teach you more about life than any Contiki trip through Thailand.

Moving out also exposes you to the rich tapestry that is humanity other than your family. Sure you meet some freaks but chances are some of your housemates will also drink beer with you.

In addition, up-close exposure to others provides an excellent opportunity to tinker with the less appealing aspects of your personality. When flatmates are not related to you by family or friendship, they won't be as shy when pointing out that you have not cleaned the bathroom for three months.

It's not all harsh reality. Flatmates inadvertently introduce you to new ways of seeing the world. From new brands of toothpaste to better bootleg DVDs, more obscure countercultures, a tastier way of making lasagne – maybe even different types of pasta altogether.

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Besides, no matter how well you and your parents get on, living at home through your 20s bears all the hallmarks of style-cramping. Beyond your 21st birthday, how many house parties do you want with mum or dad around? The thought of carrying on romantic relationships at home into your 20s or 30s is even less appealing.

The debate about not moving out is dominated by financial costs with the holy grail of buying, not renting, lurking in the background. But surely independence, some life skills and fun are worth investing in, too, even if it means you don't have that hefty house deposit at 25.

More important, there's no need to live with mum and dad to take advantage of the perks. I boomeranged home for the day to write this article and use my parents' cable TV, faster internet and better scotch. I don't think they mind me freeloading once in a while, either. So long as I don't stay past dinner.

Judith Ireland is a freelance writer.

© Judith Ireland, *The Sydney Morning Herald*, 9 January 2010

Activities

1. What is a kipper?
2. Why is the term 'boomerang' used in the article?
3. What did the Australian Bureau of Statistics analysis reveal about young Australians?
4. What was the result of overseas research in this matter?
5. Why are significant numbers of 20 and 30 year olds with full-time jobs staying at home?
6. What are the advantages of share housing that the author was referring to?
7. What are the so called 'perks' of living at home? Is it possible to enjoy these perks but still live independently? If so, how?
8. What do you think the author meant by the phrase 'the rich tapestry that is humanity'? Give examples.
9. In what context did the author use the term 'style cramping'? How is it relevant even for those who get on with their parents?
10. What basic message do you think the author is trying to convey in the article? Do you agree with this message?

As a class, come up with a list of arguments for and against staying at home into your 20s or 30s. Hold a class debate on the topic.

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3 What is homelessness?

Emma's story

When I was 13, my father left home. My mum found a new partner who soon moved in. He abused my sisters and me on a regular basis. He also used to beat my mum but he always said he was sorry, and she forgave him.

I put up with this for about a year, then, when I turned 15, I decided I couldn't take it anymore. I said to mum, 'Either he goes or I go.' Mum chose him, so I left home. I had nowhere to go, and ended up on the streets. I sometimes stayed with friends, but never for long. I moved closer to the city and started sleeping with guys I picked up on the street to get enough money to live on. I slept in abandoned houses and buildings with other young people who were just like me.

Luke's story

I was 14 when I got kicked out of home. I always seemed to be fighting with my parents. They wanted to control me and I was a bit of a rebel at the time. At first I just stayed anywhere – camped, slept in cars – wherever I could find a place to be. I didn't own anything except my clothes so it was easy to just keep moving.

One day a mate told me about a place that offered refuge accommodation. I went there to see if they could help me. The staff at the refuge organised for me to move into emergency accommodation. While I was there, my support worker helped me find a job as a labourer. I also got some information on going back to finish school. I enrolled in a TAFE course to become a plumber. Now I rent my own apartment, I've nearly finished my plumber's apprenticeship and work full time for a large construction company.

The two stories above are fictitious, but they are based on things that happen in the community. These are the kinds of things that can lead to homelessness.

Levels of homelessness

The Australian Bureau of Statistics divides the homeless into the following categories:

1. **Absolute homeless (primary homeless)**: People without conventional accommodation (living on the streets, in deserted buildings, improvised dwellings, in parks, etc.) – sometimes called 'sleeping rough'.
2. **Relative homeless (secondary and tertiary homeless)**: People staying in boarding houses, people using Supported Accommodation Assistance Program (SAAP) and other similar emergency accommodation services, or people with no secure accommodation staying temporarily with friends or relatives in private dwellings.

On Census night in 2006, the homeless population in Australia was 105 000, according to the Australian Bureau of Statistics (ABS).

Causes of homelessness

Some of the main causes of homelessness are:

- family members fighting amongst themselves can lead to one or more members leaving home
- a family member physically assaulting other family members (this is known as domestic violence)
- mental or emotional abuse
- sexual assault
- financial problems within the household, such as unemployment or gambling problems
- physical or mental illness or intellectual disability within the family
- drug and/or alcohol abuse
- family bereavement, which can strain family relationships
- accommodation problems, such as overcrowding in the home.

Sometimes more than one of these problems can occur within the one household.

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Fact or fiction

* All homeless people are older men. **FALSE**
  Homeless people are all ages, and the breakdown between males and females is roughly 50/50.
* You're not homeless if you're staying with friends. **FALSE**
  Many homeless people stay with friends or relatives, but without a permanent home, they are still homeless.
* Most homeless people sleep out on the streets or in an improvised shelter. **FALSE**
  Very few homeless people sleep out – many stay in temporary accommodation.

Getting help

As a basic human right, all people are entitled to a safe and affordable place to live. If you find yourself without a home you can seek help either through government agencies or privately run services, such as:

- State government agencies such as the Department of Community Services in NSW or the Department of Human Services in Victoria. There are similar agencies in all Australian states and territories. If you are under 18 years of age, you will be given special assistance.
- Centrelink, the federal government agency, can help with financial matters.
- Emergency organisations such as Kids Helpline (phone 1800 55 1800) or Lifeline (phone 131 114) can help if you are in urgent need of immediate housing and/or food.

Other sources of help can include organisations such as Alcoholics Anonymous, Alateen (for children who have an alcoholic in the family) and the National Children's and Youth Law Centre (called Lawstuff), as well as family members, friends, school counsellors and other personal contacts.

Activities

1 Read Emma's story and Luke's story on the previous page. In what ways are they similar? In what ways are they different?

2 Write two paragraphs suggesting possible endings to each story.

3 How do these two stories illustrate different aspects or causes of homelessness?

4 Explain the difference between relative homelessness and absolute homelessness.

5 Read the list of the causes of homelessness. Which three do you believe are the most common? Give reasons for your choice.

6 What percentage of homeless people are female?

7 Why is the statement 'Homeless people are mainly older men' wrong?

8 What is meant by 'temporary accommodation'? What kinds of accommodation do you think this might include?

9 Outline the main government agencies that provide help for homeless people.

10 What is Kids Helpline? How might it help?

Research the government agencies and other organisations in your state that might offer help to homeless people. Outline the services they provide. Check the following websites as examples:

www.centrelink.gov.au

www.community.nsw.gov.au

www.dhs.vic.gov.au

www.communities.qld.gov.au

www.lawstuff.org.au

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4 Different types of accommodation

There are many different types of accommodation available. It is important to be aware of all the options available to you. The main differences between the options are cost, location and level of independence. Do you want to share with others, or would you prefer to live alone? Will you cook your own meals, or would you prefer somebody did that for you? Different kinds of accommodation suit a range of needs. These options are explained below.

Boarding

Full board means that you will live, or 'board', in a family home and all or most meals are supplied. These arrangements can vary widely. You can generally be guaranteed your own room, but would normally share bathroom/toilet facilities and eat in the family dining room.

Some properties are classified as 'boarding houses'. These places have a landlord or caretaker who runs the premises, either living in the property or controlling things from another location.

Meals may be provided (in which case you are a 'boarder') but if you only receive cleaning services, linen or other household items you are a 'lodger'. There will be a shared kitchen and bathroom, but there may be no communal, or shared, living space. Tenants have no say in who shares the boarding house with them. The owner chooses the tenants.

You should be aware that living in boarding houses means you don't have the protections available to renters (who are protected by the Residential Tenancies Act). This means you could be asked to leave without notice.

Rental accommodation

Rental accommodation means paying a set amount of money each week or month to rent a property. This property can either be shared (in which case, all the costs are shared among the tenants) or individual. Types of rented accommodation include:

Studios

Studios are very small apartments made up of one main room without a separate bedroom. The main room might include a bed, lounge and a small kitchen (kitchenette). The bathroom is usually separate, although in some cases it may be shared. A studio has the advantage of allowing you to live alone relatively cheaply.

Flats, units and apartments

Places with one or more separate bedrooms are usually flats, units or apartments. They vary in the number of bedrooms (usually between 1 and 3). As well as bedrooms, they usually have a separate living area, kitchen, bathroom and sometimes laundry. Some apartment buildings have a communal laundry area which may be located on the ground floor or basement and shared with other units.

Houses, townhouses, semi-detached houses and terrace houses

Houses are identified as freestanding properties. Townhouses, semi-detached houses and terrace houses will share one or more common walls with a neighbour. Most houses have 2, 3 or 4 bedrooms, a kitchen, bathroom, living area and laundry. Many houses will also have a garden and/or courtyard area.

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Share accommodation

Share accommodation is often preferred by students looking to save money. The cost of rent and bills is split between the occupants, and usually everyone provides some of the furniture. Rental properties can be shared by several tenants. Other kinds of shared accommodation include:

- hostels, which usually have secure private rooms with shared cooking and washing facilities
- student residences, which are often based on campus and usually include a furnished room with meals provided for an extra charge.
- accommodation in exchange for work, which requires you to do work around the house in exchange for free or cheap accommodation.

Simon T of Surry Hills ***Available: 27/2/2013***

Our home: Terrace house
Rent range: $166 to $185 per week

Sarah L of Bexley/Rockdale ***Available: Immediately***

Our home: Apartment
Rent range: $186 to $205 per week
About us: Male/s and female/s, 18 to 24 years, Non-smoker/s

Jack B of Richmond

Availability: available to move immediately

Further information: Hi, I'm Jack, 18 years old and looking for a place close to the inner city. No preference on meals.

Personal qualities: I am looking for friendly people who work hard and like to socialise.

Details: Mobile 0410 111 000

Activities

1 Why is an awareness of all the different types of accommodation that are available so important before making a decision?

2 How might prices affect your decision? Give examples.

3 How might your feelings about your independence guide your choice?

4 Explain the main features of the following accommodation types and the differences between each one:

- ***a*** boarding houses
- ***b*** studios
- ***c*** apartments
- ***d*** hostels
- ***e*** student residences
- ***f*** free accommodation in exchange for work
- ***g*** townhouses

5 What protection do you have in rental accommodation as opposed to staying in a boarding house?

6 Under what circumstance might a boarding house be preferable to renting?

7 Study the two accommodation advertisements by Simon and Sarah (above). In what ways are they different?

8 Study the advertisement by Jack B of Richmond. What sort of person do you think he is, judging from his ad? Would you be happy to share accommodation with Jack? Give reasons.

Imagine that you are looking for a housemate or looking for a room. Write an advertisement outlining your main criteria.

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5 How do I find a place to live?

Finding a place to live can be an exhausting process. There are so many things to consider. It's worth thinking it through carefully though, to ensure that you find a place that meets your needs.

Consider the type of accommodation that you want

There are many different types of accommodation, including boarding houses, share accommodation and independent living in a rented house or apartment. They vary in price as well as in the level of independence you have and the amount of cleaning or shopping you may need to do.

Note: See the previous unit for more information about different types of accommodation.

Location is another big factor in finding a place to live

Living close to your place of work or study is convenient, but suitable places can be hard to find because of the demand. This demand means that they are usually also relatively expensive. Places that are further away are often cheaper and may well be better quality, however travel expenses such as public transport fares or petrol costs have to be factored in. Living at home may be cheaper, but again transport costs and travel time need to be considered.

How do you find a place?

Visit real estate agents

Real estate agents have lists of rental accommodation available in their area. Visit agents in the area where you would like to live. Real estate agents can give you all the information you need about rental accommodation and can arrange inspections of any properties you might be interested in renting.

Get online

There are also several major real estate websites online which list current properties available, often including photos. The following websites could get you started:

www.domain.com.au
www.flatmates.com.au
www.flatmatefinders.com.au
www.realestate.com.au

Check newspaper advertisements

The daily newspapers have a section for real estate which usually includes rental properties and share accommodation. The main national newspapers, such as the *Sydney Morning Herald* in New South Wales, *The Age* in Victoria and the *Courier Mail* in Queensland have the largest coverage, particularly the Saturday editions of these papers. The classifieds section of local newspapers can also be useful.

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Check noticeboards

Information about accommodation, especially share accommodation, can be found on the noticeboards at universities, TAFE colleges, workplaces or on community noticeboards at supermarkets and local cafes.

Ask around

Sometimes you can find accommodation through word of mouth and recommendations from friends. Let people know what you're looking for, and where, in case somebody hears of anything that might suit your needs.

Activities

1 If you don't have a car, what factors would you need to consider when deciding where to live?

2 What other factors might determine where you want to live?

3 Consider the main types of accommodation available to young people. Explain which one you would prefer and why?

4 How would you go about finding a place? Why would you choose this method?

5 Yusuf decided that he wanted to live in a place close to the university. He looked at the university noticeboard and chose the first place listed. Do you think that Yusuf was wise to do this? What would you have advised him to do?

6 Tora found a place to live in shared accommodation. Within a week she found that her housemates were rude and uncooperative. If you were Tora's friend what advice would you give her?

7 Advertisements for rental properties often use abbreviations. Match the abbreviations in column 1 with their full meaning in column 2.

Column 1	*Column 2*
ac	ensuite bathroom
lug	lounge
ens	furnished
dbl gar	walk-in pantry
furn	air conditioning
ldry	modern
lng	double garage
bir	laundry
wi pant	built in robes
mod	lock up garage

Use the internet to find the types of accommodation you would consider if you were looking for a place to live. Select a suburb close to where you would like to work or study. Find two or three possible accommodation options and list the advantages and disadvantages of each option.

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6 Choosing your accommodation

There are many factors to consider when looking for a place to live.

Things to think about

These factors differ depending on the type of accommodation you are looking for. If you are after a rental property, the terms of the lease agreement are important. If you will be sharing a place, housemates need to be considered. Neighbourhood facilities and transport are likely to be important whatever the type of accommodation.

Property condition

The condition of the place is also important, including things such as cleanliness and safety. Above all, cost is likely to play a big part in your decision. This checklist can help you to decide if a property meets your needs.

Feature	Yes (✓)	Comment
Is the property clean and well-maintained?		
Do all appliances and switches work? • stove • hot water • heating • air conditioning • fans • light switches		
Is water pressure strong?		
Do taps leak?		
Is there a laundry or nearby laundromat?		
Is there a TV aerial connection?		
Are there any obvious repairs needed?		
Is the property within walking distance of public transport (if needed)?		
Is car parking available (if needed)?		
Is the property fitted with smoke detectors?		
Are there places to buy food and groceries nearby?		
Do all locks on doors and windows work, and are there keys available? Is there an alarm system?		

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Activities

1. What message is the illustration on the previous page trying to convey?
2. Why do you think some people prefer to live alone rather than in shared accommodation? What are the advantages and disadvantages of each?
3. Why is cost such an important factor in choosing somewhere to live?
4. Copy or write out the checklist regarding property condition. Think of some additional items that you might like to consider and add them to the checklist. Items you may wish to consider include: noise, gates, light fittings, power points, windows, and storage. When you have a complete list of questions, tick the ones that are not important to you personally.
5. Make a list of what you believe to be the five most important factors in the checklist and explain the reasons for your choice.
6. Danielle had enrolled at a university a long way from her parents' home. She only had a limited budget and decided on share accommodation with some friends. Which items on the checklist would she be most likely to tick as 'not important'? Use the extended list that you created in the previous question.
7. Brett was lucky enough to score a well-paid job in the building industry. He is a person who values his privacy and independence. He also used the checklist to help him decide where to live. Which items do you think Brett would most likely tick as 'not important'?
8. How important do you think the issues of safety and security are? Why? Could this issue affect your choice of location? Explain.

In groups, discuss the checklist each member has constructed (see question 4). Make a list of the most common items that have been added to the list. Discuss why these things are important.

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7 What is a lease?

Read the definitions below to help you understand the terminology used when agreeing to rent a property.

landlord	the person who owns a property and is prepared to let it
tenant	the person who has permission to rent the landlord's property to live in
lease	the rental contract stating the amount of rent to be paid, the method of payment, length of time and other conditions (see below). It is sometimes known as a tenancy agreement.
rent	the amount of money, per week that the tenant must pay to the landlord (or agent)
bond	the money paid up-front as security in case of damage to the property

Tenancy agreements can be either verbal or written. It is better to have a written agreement because a written agreement:

- gives you more security provided you follow the terms of the lease
- means you cannot be asked to leave before the lease expires
- means the amount of rent you have to pay is fixed for the term of the lease
- gives you the right to have repairs done provided they are reasonable.

There are two types of tenancy agreements – **fixed-term** and **periodic**. A **fixed-term** agreement is for a set period of time, often 6 months. A **periodic** agreement is an arrangement which runs from week to week or month to month. Written agreements must follow the wording of an official 'Residential Tenancy Agreement' form. A simplified version is illustrated below:

RESIDENTIAL TENANCY AGREEMENT

THIS AGREEMENT is made on ...../...../..... at .....

BETWEEN

LANDLORD Name(s).....

Address.....

Name of Landlord's agent.....Address.....

AND

TENANT Name(s).....

PREMISES The landlord gives the tenant the right to occupy the premises at .....

.....

RENT The rent is $..... per week, payable every .....,
starting on ...../...../..... and payable in advance.

Conditions: *1*
2
3

Signed: Landlord or agent:..... Tenant:.....

Conditions

In a lease agreement there will generally be a number of conditions that the landlord and the tenant agree upon. These may include things like:

- who is responsible for keeping the place clean, and the standards of cleanliness
- who is responsible for repairs, and how these should be done
- who is responsible for mowing the lawn or maintaining the garden (if there is one).

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Tips for tenants

Before moving in

- Always read the lease (or Residential Tenancy Agreement) carefully before signing it. Never sign a blank sheet of paper.
- If you are unsure about anything in the lease, get some professional advice.
- The Office of Fair Trading in your state will probably have a guide for tenants that you should be able to access free of charge. Familiarise yourself with your rights and responsibilities as a tenant.
- Check that the premises are clean and safe. You will probably have to pay a Bond, in which case you should carefully check the Condition Report (see unit 9).
- Ensure you get receipts for any rent paid up front.

Before moving out

- Make sure you pay the final rent owing.
- Arrange for the electricity, gas, water and telephone to be disconnected, and pay the final bills.
- Check that the premises are in good order and condition.
- Make sure that you have packed all your belongings.
- Organise for the landlord or agent to return any bond money paid.
- Leave a forwarding address with the landlord or agent so you can receive any mail delivered to the premises after you leave.
- Check the terms of your agreement to ensure you have met all conditions for leaving (such as cleaning or any repairs).

Activities

1 Match the following terms to their correct definitions:

Terms	*Definitions*
rent	***a*** The up-front money paid as security in case of damage to the property.
tenant	***b*** The person who wishes to rent a property.
landlord	***c*** The person who owns a property and is prepared to let it.
premises	***d*** The rental contract stating the amount of rent to be paid, the method of payment, length of time and other conditions.
bond	***e*** The amount of money per week that the tenant must pay to the landlord (or agent).
lease	***f*** The property that is being offered for lease.

2 True or false: A lease is the same as a Residential Tenancy Agreement.

3 Who are the main parties to a lease?

4 What other information is shown on a lease?

5 Explain why it is better to have a written tenancy agreement rather than a verbal one.

6 Why are certain conditions generally included on a lease? Give examples.

7 Study the tips for tenants listed above. Choose two from each list and explain why you think they are important.

8 What is the role of the Office or Department of Fair Trading?

Imagine you are a landlord. Describe the property that you own, and make a list of the conditions that you would want included in the lease before you agreed to let a tenant rent your property.

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8 The bond and the rent

After signing a lease you will need to pay both bond and rent. It is important to note that these are separate payments.

The bond

As the owners of property, landlords need to have some way of protecting their assets. The bond is an up-front payment made by the tenant before they move into the property. If they cause any damage to the property while they are living there, the cost of the repair is taken out of the bond and the tenant may only get part of their bond money back. If a tenant has not caused any damage to the property, he or she is entitled to have their bond money returned at the end of the tenancy.

The bond money is held by the Rental Bond Board (NSW) or the Residential Tenancies Bond Authority (Victoria), or similar organisations in other states and territories. At the end of the tenancy, the tenant can apply to get their bond money back, but the agreement of the landlord is required before the money is released.

The rent

Tenants are expected to pay rent in full and on time. The rent is usually paid in advance. The landlord or agent is entitled to take action if rent is not paid in full on the due date.

Paying the rent

There are several methods of payment available to tenants (see box at right) and the method agreed upon may be included in the residential lease. Some payment methods may incur extra costs, such as credit card charges or fees.

- Cash
- Cheque
- Credit card
- Direct debit
- EFTPOS

When the rent is paid the landlord (or agent) must issue a receipt. If the rent is paid in person the tenant must be given a receipt on the spot. For other payments a receipt must be sent or available for pick-up within five days. A tenant should always keep a record of the rent paid as proof in case there are any disputes.

A receipt should contain the following information:

- the tenant's name
- the address of the property
- the date
- the total amount paid
- the period that the payment covers.

Problems with paying rent

Tenants sometimes have trouble meeting their regular rental payments, for a variety of reasons. If you run into trouble with your rent, consumer affairs advice is available from state government agencies (such as the NSW Office of Fair Trading or Consumer Affairs Victoria). There are similar agencies in the other states. When experiencing problems with rental payments, bear in mind the following do's and don'ts:

Do

- contact your landlord or agent as soon as possible to explain any problems and try to work out a solution
- seek assistance from state or local consumer affairs organisations.

Don't

- withhold payment of rent because you are not satisfied with lack of action on repairs
- fail to pay the final weeks' rent at the end of the lease – this can be deducted from any bond money owing to you.

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If your rent is more than 14 days overdue the landlord can give you notice to vacate and apply to the courts for an order to evict you. This is not automatic, however – tenants do have rights and a landlord cannot simply lock a tenant out for not paying their rent. A legal procedure must be followed and the matter resolved in court.

Increasing the rent

Landlords cannot increase rent at will. There are various state laws which govern rent increases. The rules surrounding rent increases state that:

- The landlord must first give notice (generally 60 days written notice) of a rent increase.
- The tenant may appeal against any rent increase which they believe to be excessive.
- If the tenant cannot successfully negotiate the changes with the landlord, he or she may approach the Residential Tenancies Tribunal (NSW) or the Victorian Civil and Administration Tribunal (Victoria) to have the dispute settled. Other states have similar bodies.

Disputes

Disputes between landlords and tenants can occur for various reasons. Problems often arise when the tenant requests that certain repairs are carried out and the landlord or agent either does not act or disputes the need for the repairs. These disputes can escalate and sometimes need to be resolved by the relevant Tribunal for that state.

Activities

1 How would you explain the difference between rent money and bond money?

2 Explain what happens to the bond money at the end of a tenancy. Under what circumstances might bond money not be returned to the tenant?

3 Indicate whether the following statements are true or false:

- ***a*** Rent is generally payable in advance.
- ***b*** Receipts must be issued to tenants for rent paid.
- ***c*** Landlords can increase the rent whenever they like.
- ***d*** All bond money is automatically returned to tenants at the end of a tenancy.
- ***e*** If you fail to pay rent after 14 days the landlord can automatically evict you.

Individually, or in groups, use the internet to search for the consumer advice relating to renting in your state. Compare with a different state and make up a table showing the similarities and differences between the two states.

4 Explain why it is better for a tenant who has problems in paying the rent to talk to the landlord or agent as a first step.

5 Explain why it is not a good idea to withhold rent simply because requested repairs have not been done.

6 Jodie was renting an apartment when she received notice of an increase in the rent. The agent informed her that the rent increase would take effect immediately. What advice would you give Jodie in relation to her rights in this matter?

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9 The condition report

A condition report is a document that describes the general condition of the premises being let, including fittings and fixtures. It is necessary in situations where a bond has been paid. It is the duty of the landlord or his or her agent to prepare a condition report on the premises. They must give two copies of the signed condition report to the tenant before the tenant can occupy the premises. A fine can be imposed if this is not done. The tenant must fill out and promptly return the condition report to the landlord or agent.

The condition report is an extremely important document. It may be used as evidence if there is a future dispute about who is responsible for any cleaning, damage, or missing items. It is important that tenants keep their copy of the condition report until the end of the tenancy.

The landlord or agent has the right to claim some, or all of the bond money if there has been damage, if items are missing or if the premises are left dirty and untidy at the end of the tenancy. The condition report is therefore crucial as it is an agreement of the state of the premises prior to the tenancy. This protects the tenant from having to pay for any damage that they are not responsible for.

Condition Report

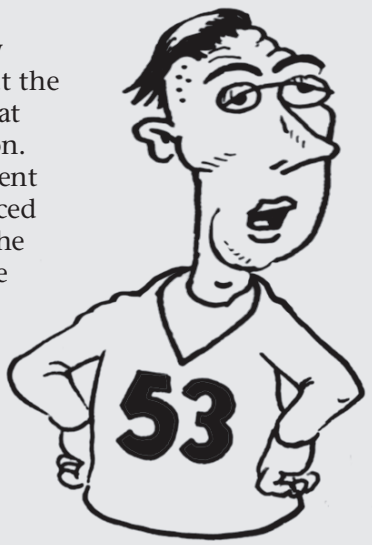
Premises: *Unit 1, 37 York Street, Edsville*		**Working**	**Clean**	**Undamaged**	**Comments**
Kitchen	Light fittings	Y	Y	Y	
	Floor covering	Y	Y	Y	
	Walls	Y	Y	Y	
	Stove	Y			
	Oven	Y	Y	N	Chip on bottom corner of enamel
	Rangehood	N/A	N/A	N/A	
	Sink and taps	Y	Y	Y	
	Benchtops	Y	N	N	Burn mark in centre
	Power points	Y	Y	Y	
	Windows/blinds/curtains	Y	Y	Y	
	Cupboards and drawers	Y	Y	Y	
Bedroom	Light fittings	Y	Y	Y	
	Floor coverings	Y	Y	Y	

Chloe and Jake

Chloe and Jake signed a lease and checked the condition report for the premises they were about to rent. Chloe noticed that the carpet in the living room was dirty and badly stained. She recorded this on the condition report. The landlord did not arrange to have the carpet cleaned. At the end of the tenancy the landlord claimed that Chloe and Jake had left the premises in a dirty state and that the carpet had been stained. The landlord refused to return the bond money.

Ryan

Before Ryan moved into his new apartment he had a quick look at the condition report and decided that everything was in good condition. At the end of his tenancy the agent inspected the premises and noticed that there were dirty marks on the walls, that two light fittings were broken and that a power point in the kitchen had been pulled out of the wall. The agent refused to return Ryan's bond money despite Ryan's claims that it was like that when he first moved in.



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Sally

Sally very carefully checked the condition report she received. She pointed out several things that were not up to standard. The kitchen stove did not work, there were chipped tiles in the bathroom and two of the power points in the living room did not work. She asked the agent to have these things fixed. The agent checked with the owner (landlord) who promised to fix them but never did. At the end of the tenancy Sally requested the full bond back but the landlord refused, claiming that she had caused the damage to the property.

Activities

1 In your own words, describe a condition report and its purpose.

2 Who prepares the condition report? What happens when it is prepared?

3 Why is it important for the tenant to check the condition report closely?

4 At the end of the tenancy what rights does the landlord have? What role does the condition report play in this?

Create a sample condition report. Complete one for your classroom, noting any damage to paint or carpet, any stains, etc. Fill out another condition report for the place where you live. Think about the kinds of details that you would want to have on record before signing a lease.

5 Read the story of Chloe and Jake on the previous page then answer the following questions:

- ***a*** What did Chloe point out in the condition report?
- ***b*** What was the landlord's initial response?
- ***c*** What was the landlord's response at the end of the tenancy?
- ***d*** Do you think that Chloe and Jake had the right to have their bond money returned?
- ***e*** Under what circumstances could Chloe and Jake be in the wrong, and therefore lose their bond money?

6 Read the story of Ryan on the previous page then answer the following questions:

- ***a*** Was Ryan initially at fault at the beginning of his tenancy? How?
- ***b*** Was Ryan entitled to get his bond money back? Give reasons.
- ***c*** What should Ryan have done in regard to the condition report?
- ***d*** Do you think the agent or landlord would be entitled to think that Ryan, or his friends, had done the damage himself? Explain.

7 Read the story of Sally above then answer the following questions:

- ***a*** What did Sally do that Ryan failed to do in regard to the condition report?
- ***b*** If you were Sally, what would you point out to the landlord or agent when they refused to return the bond money? Does Sally have any rights in this matter?

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10 Connecting services

When moving into a new home you will need to have services such as gas, electricity, water and telephone connected. These services are known as 'utilities'. Having these services connected involves setting up an account with one of the providers of these services.

If you are renting, some of these services, such as water, may be included in the rent, and others, such as gas, may not be available in the property you are renting.

Energy costs

Gas and electricity are both forms of energy. There are various energy providers and it can be worth shopping around for the best deals. Some energy providers offer green energy. This is usually more expensive, but it means that some or all of your electricity usage is matched with energy from renewable sources, such as wind or solar power. This offsets the environmental impacts of using electricity that is produced from burning fossil fuels, such as coal.

Many homes are also connected to a gas supply. Gas is mainly used for heating, and sometimes also for cooking. Check whether gas is available in the property, and whether there are any appliances in the home that run on gas.

Choosing a provider

You may be able to choose which energy provider you want to open an account with. When making this decision, it can be helpful to compare energy costs, off-peak rates, connection and disconnection fees and green energy options. There are several energy providers to choose from, including:

- Energy Australia
- Integral Energy
- AGL
- Australian Power and Gas
- Jackgreen
- Origin Energy
- Powerdirect
- TRU Energy.

Energy bills

Energy bills usually contain a lot of information. They can sometimes be difficult to read, but they can tell you a lot about your energy use. Your energy bill will list your electricity use, which is calculated in kilowatt hours (kWh) as well as showing the pattern of your energy consumption, usually on a graph (see below).

XYZ ENERGY

Account Number: 123 456 789
Amount payable: $439.50

Quarterly Electricity Account

Due Date: 1 /11/13

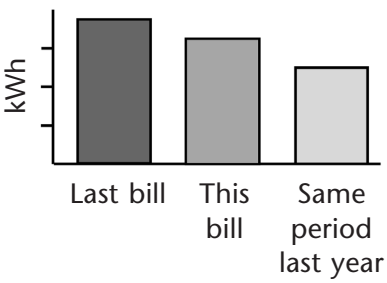
Location: 21 Smith Street, Jonestown

Electricity 1/7/13 – 30/9/13	$399.55
GST at 10%	$ 39.95
TOTAL AMOUNT PAYABLE	**$439.50**

Energy used and costs

Meter	***This reading***	***Last reading***	***Energy used***	***Rate***	***Cost***
Domestic	86020.8	82874.7	3146.1	12.700c	$399.55
Off peak					

Average daily usage



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Telephone costs

Telephone costs include both landlines and mobile phones. Telephone costs are rarely included in the rent. If you need a landline, you will need to open an account and get the phone connected. This usually involves a connection fee and then ongoing monthly fees and call charges.

Paying bills

There are several ways you can pay your bills. These include:

- by phone (Bpay, debit or credit card)
- in person at Australia Post (cash, cheque, debit or credit card)
- by mail (cheque).

Overdue accounts often result in late payment fees being charged, so it is a good idea to note the due date on all bills received.

Renewable energy

Most electricity is produced from burning fossil fuels, such as coal, oil and gas. These resources are limited and will one day run out. Burning fossil fuels to produce energy also harms the environment. Renewable energy is energy that is produced from sustainable sources – sources that will not run out. Forms of renewable energy include solar power, wind power, geothermal power, hydro-electric power and tidal power. At this point, renewable energy is more expensive to produce in Australia than coal-based energy. However this may change over time as new technology could develop, if a carbon tax or an emissions trading scheme is introduced or if more people switch to renewable energy.

Activities

1 What are the services you are most likely to have to pay for if you are renting? Explain why these services may not be included in the rent.

2 What is meant by the term 'energy' in this context? What does it include?

3 What is meant by 'renewable energy'? Give examples of forms of renewable energy.

4 Why is renewable energy more expensive than coal-based energy in Australia?

5 What is meant by 'energy providers'? Give three examples of Australian energy providers.

6 Study the energy bill for the XYZ Energy company as shown above.

- ***a*** How often are energy bills sent out? How can you tell?
- ***b*** What was the amount payable and when was it due?
- ***c*** How is the electricity used calculated? What is the unit of measure?
- ***d*** Why might the average daily usage graph be useful?

7 Describe the different ways you can pay your electricity bill. Which would be your preferred method and why?

8 What are the advantages and disadvantages of having a landline telephone in rented premises?

Research two different energy providers that offer green power. Find out how much they charge for green power and how much for normal power. How much more expensive is green power? Which of the two energy providers you researched is cheaper?

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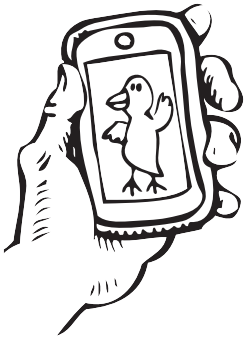
11 Communication

Communication is an essential part of day-to-day life. It takes many forms. There are two major forms of communication technology which have become a significant part of how we communicate every day. They are the telephone and the computer.

The telephone



If you are sharing a house that has a landline it may be necessary to work out a system for paying the bills. This can be either an even split of each bill, including line rental and all call charges, or each person can be responsible for their calls and the line rental is shared equally. This can be time-consuming to calculate, but most phone companies itemise each phone call made, especially long distance calls or calls to premium-rate numbers.

The computer

Most people own either a desktop computer or a laptop. When moving into a new house you may also want to arrange to have internet access. If two or more people in a household are sharing a computer there needs to be an agreement about what kind of plan is needed and who pays the monthly charges to the ISP (Internet Service Provider).

Useful terms

Broadband	A range of high-speed internet services, including ADSL, cable and satellite.
Dial-up	A basic internet connection that runs through the telephone line. When connected to the Internet the telephone cannot be used
ADSL	Stands for Asymmetric Digital Subscriber Line. ADSL is an internet connection that runs through the telephone line but allows use of the telephone and internet at the same time.
Upload	If you send any material via the internet you are said to be uploading it. For example, sending emails or entering a web address into your browser.
Download	When you receive material from the internet you are downloading it. This includes any web pages that you view as well as emails you receive and file attachments that you open.
File sharing	This happens when you allow other users to upload a file, such as music or videos, from your computer.
Megabytes and gigabytes	How units of information on computers are measured. A megabyte is equal to 1000 kilobytes or 1 000 000 bytes. A gigabyte is 1000 megabytes. A typical three-minute song will be about 30 megabytes. Text files use fewer megabytes than pictures or audio files.
ISP	Stands for Internet Service Provider – a company that provides an Internet connection to customers. ISPs include Bigpond, iinet, Optus and Dodo.

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Hints for internet use

- Research the options. There are lots of different plans and prices on offer. Consider your usage requirements. Most internet plans offer a certain amount of usage for a monthly fee. Exceeding the limit can result in excess usage charges. It may be better to select a plan with a higher limit, even if you don't use it all, rather than selecting a plan with a lower limit and incurring charges if you exceed it.
- Find out how flexible your plan is – can you change it? After a while you may want to change your plan to a higher or lower limit. Most providers allow this, but it is good to be aware of what the alternatives are and how easy it is to change.

Toula and Omar decided to share an inner city apartment. They each had their own mobile phones but neither had their own computer. They decided to share equally in the cost of a new laptop. They checked out several ISPs and decided on one that provided cheap monthly rates.

After several months they noticed that the monthly bills were becoming increasingly large and they soon found they were unable to pay them. Toula noticed that Omar seemed to be on the computer for hours every day while she didn't use it much at all, except to field a few emails each day. An argument soon broke out regarding the situation.

- Protect yourself against computer viruses with virus protection software. Also guard against unauthorised use by keeping your password private. It is best to memorise your password rather than writing it down, and change it regularly. Be wary of emails received from unknown sources and delete them without opening them. Never open an attachment from someone you don't know and trust. If you have a complaint with your ISP, try to resolve it with them in the first instance. If that is unsuccessful, contact the Telecommunications Industry Ombudsman. They can be contacted by phone on 1800 062 058, or by email at tio@tio.com.au.

Activities

1 Explain how telephone and computer technology have revolutionised our everyday lives.

2 What are the main differences between having a landline telephone account and a mobile phone account?

3 Explain the difference between broadband and dial-up. Which is better and why?

4 What is the difference between downloading and uploading information? Give examples.

5 Complete the following equations:

1 megabyte = ____ kilobytes 1 gigabyte = _____megabytes 1 terabyte = _____ gigabytes

6 What is file sharing? Give an example. Is file sharing legal? Explain.

7 What do the following letters stand for?
What do these terms mean?

a ISP ***b*** ADSL

8 List three things you should consider before signing up with an ISP. Why are they important?

9 How should you protect yourself when using the internet?

10 What was the problem with Toula and Omar sharing a computer? How could this be resolved?

11 If you have a complaint with your telecommunications company what should you do in the first instance? If that does not resolve the problem what other options do you have?

Individually, or in groups, research the kinds of internet plans currently on offer. Recommend a plan for:

a) someone who only uses the internet to check their email once a day

b) someone who uses the internet for work, sending lots of large files and visiting numerous websites.

Explain why.

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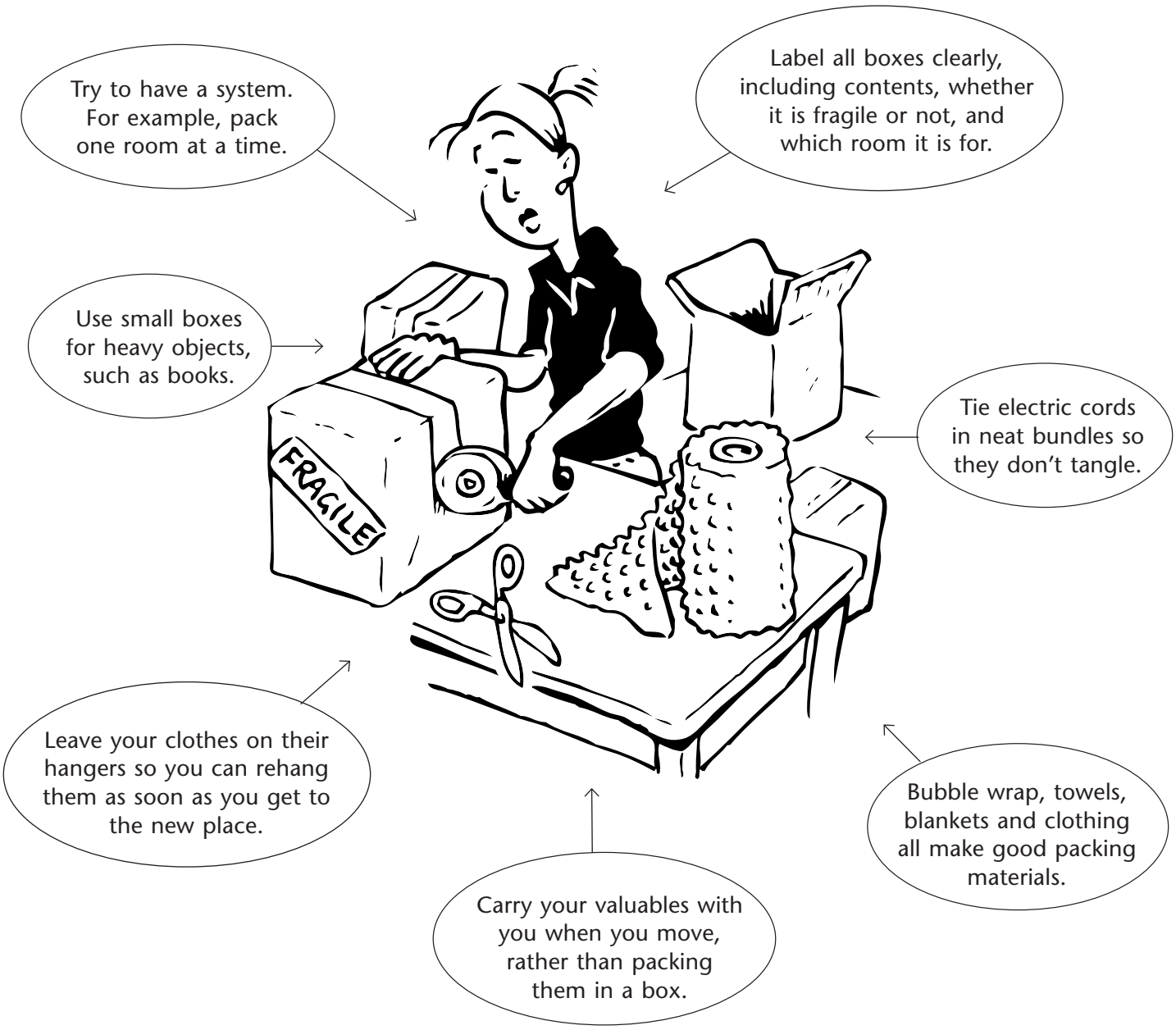
12 Moving day

Moving to a new home can be a daunting task and requires some planning. You need to consider how you are going to move all your belongings to your new home. This will depend on:

- the amount and size of your belongings
- your transport options – you could:
  - get help from family and friends who have vehicles to help transport your things
  - hire a van and organise people to help you
  - use a removalist. Note that some companies charge based on an hourly rate while others use a combination of time and distance travelled.
- your budget. For example, if your budget allows for this, you may opt to have a removalist company do all the packing as well as the moving.

Tips for packing



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Bill

Bill was moving out of home for the first time. He didn't think he had much stuff, so he didn't worry about packing until a couple of days before. Once he started to pack he realised he had a lot more than he'd thought – he ended up having to throw it all in boxes at the last minute! Bill borrowed his friend's ute, and asked a few mates to help him with the move. Once he was all moved in, he bought everyone pizza as a thank you.

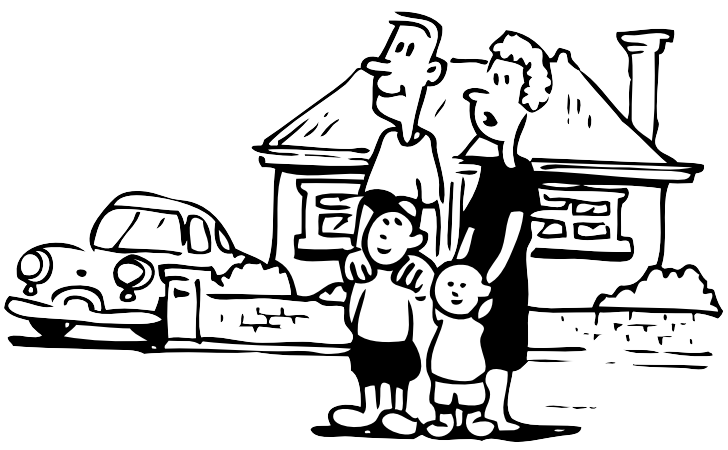
Ally

Ally was moving from a house into a unit. She had a busy, demanding job and didn't have time to pack. She also knew it would be a tight squeeze to fit all her furniture into the new place, and she was worried that some of her things might get damaged in the move. Ally decided it was worth hiring removalists to pack and move all her things. It meant spending a bit more money, but it saved her a lot of stress and time.

Activities

1. Why is it important to plan well before moving house?
2. Why is it important to start early when packing?
3. How would the amount and size of your belongings affect the way you move house?
4. What transport options do you have when moving? Explain the circumstances in which you might use each one.
5. How might your budget affect the way you organise your move?
6. Read the story about Bill. What were his costs when he moved house? Should Bill have been better organised?
7. Read Ally's story. Do you think she should have asked friends and family to help her move, like Bill did? Why might this not have worked?
8. Look at the packing equipment illustrated on the previous page. Can you think of anything else that you might need when packing?
9. Study the tips for packing. Taking each tip in turn, explain why they are important.

Working in groups, imagine you share a house with friends and are about to move house. Decide which suburb you're moving from, and where you are moving to, and then plan your move. Locate the websites of two removalists and compare their prices. How much extra do they charge for packing? Work out the cost of your move.



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13 What do I need to buy?

Some premises come fully furnished but if you don't have any furniture and you are moving into an unfurnished place, there will be some items you need. If you haven't lived out of home before there may also be other basics that you will need. What do you need immediately? What can wait? How do you proceed from here? You can divide your requirements into two categories:

- **essentials** – things you need to have as soon as possible
- **options** – things you can live without for a while.

Essentials

Basic furniture

You will need some items of furniture for your new home. A bed is important, to ensure you have somewhere to sleep. A table and chairs will provide you with somewhere to eat, and could also serve as a desk if you are studying. You may also need a couch to provide a place to relax or to entertain friends.

Basic appliances

Essential kitchen appliances are likely to include a refrigerator, a stove and an oven. Most properties will have a stove and an oven installed. Other appliances that you may consider to be essential include a washing machine and a vacuum cleaner.

Other basics

Other items that you will need include cutlery and crockery, such as plates, bowls, cups, pots and pans. You may also need to buy sheets, towels and pillows.

Options

Expensive furniture is not necessary. Some people make do with milk crates to put things on, such as the television or stereo, until they can afford something else. Small kitchen appliances, such as rice cookers and sandwich toasters can be handy but are options, rather than essentials. Although a television, computer and mobile phone may be seen as essential by many people, others may be able to live without them.

Making some choices

Here are some of the choices you may need to make:

- Do you want a landline or a mobile phone – or both?
- Will you use a laundromat or buy a washing machine?
- Do you need to buy more furniture, or get rid of some, if you are moving into a smaller place?
- Should you consider contents insurance, if you don't already have a policy?
- Would you prefer to buy new or second hand? Websites such as eBay and the Trading Post can be a good source of second-hand goods. Will you buy furniture and appliances or hire them? Hiring appliances means you need less money up-front, but this can work out to be more expensive in the long run.
- When buying new items for a shared house, will you have joint ownership or make individual purchases? Joint ownership costs each person less money, but problems could arise if you later move to different places.

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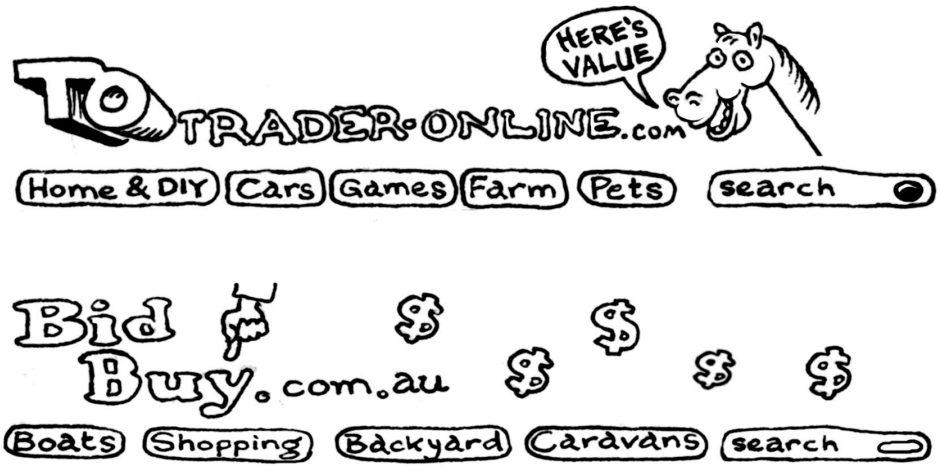

Activities

1 Imagine that you and a friend have just moved into an unfurnished flat. You have both been living at home and have no furniture. Make a list of the items you believe you would need to have as soon as you move in.

2 From the list you have just made, select items that you could possibly obtain without having to go out and buy them brand new. Give reasons for your choice of items.

3 Do you consider a television an essential item? Give reasons for and against.

4 Mia and Sarah were good friends and moved into a flat together. They decided to buy a lounge for $1000 and share the cost equally. However, after two years, they went their separate ways. What should they do with the lounge? Explain their options.

5 Three friends, Jack, Tom and Harry decide to share a flat together. Jack and Tom wanted to buy a plasma TV but Harry was not so keen as he had just enrolled in a university course and wanted no distractions. Write a short play in which the three are discussing the pros and cons of buying the TV. You might like to continue the script below.

Jack: Can't you see it? The plasma would be perfect on this wall. Can you imagine?

Tom: Yeah, absolutely. There are so many great shows on now, and we could watch footy on the weekends.

Harry: But I need to study at night.

6 Study the two mocked up websites for Trader Online and BidBuy above, and look at real online shopping sites. Answer the following questions:

- ***a*** What is meant by the term 'categories'? Give three examples.
- ***b*** How would you start to sell things on these websites? What would you click on to get started?
- ***c*** What is the difference between the 'sign in' button and the 'register' button?
- ***d*** How would you go about finding something to buy?
- ***e*** What sort of items would you expect to find under 'Home & DIY'?

Individually or in groups, brainstorm a list of places where you could buy second-hand goods other than eBay and the Trading Post. Choose an item, such as a television or kitchen appliance, and compare the price of buying it new to how much you could get the same item for second-hand. Make a list of the pros and cons of buying the item new versus second-hand.

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14 What will it cost?

Although you may have a long list of things you need to buy, you also need to consider the costs. This means assessing your savings to see what you can afford to buy. If you are sharing with others you may be able to pool your savings. You may need to consider taking out a loan. If so, make sure you are aware of the loan conditions and ongoing payments.

To give you a guide, here are some average costs for second-hand furniture and appliances.

Item	*Cost*
➨ Single bed	$100–$200
➨ Double bed	$300–$500
➨ Lounge suite	$250–$500
➨ Dining table and chairs	$200–$700
➨ Bookshelves	$50–$250
➨ Refrigerator	$350–$700
➨ Washing machine	$250–$500
➨ Sofa bed lounge	$250–$500
➨ Television set	$200–$2000
➨ MP3 player	$50–$200

*These prices are intended as a rough guide only

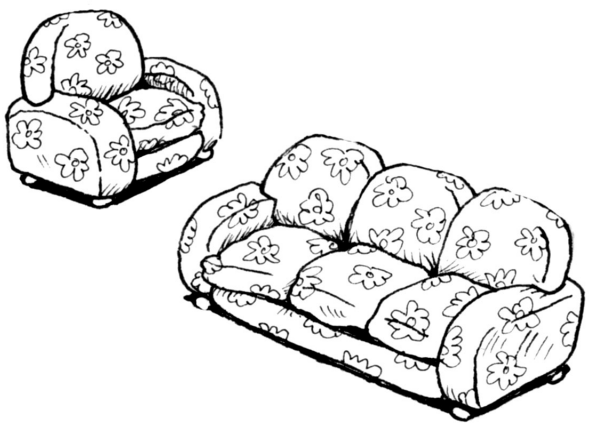
For sale

Lounge suite, one 3-seater and one armchair. Top quality.

BOX HILL NORTH

Lounge suite, one 3-seater and one armchair. Floral canvas covering. Top quality.

Item no. TP003387307



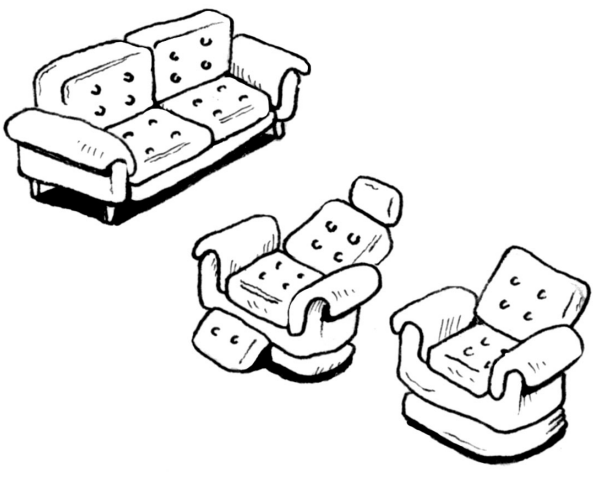
Price: $250 Ad exp. 15 July 2013
Call John, 0400 000 000

Lounge suite, two-seater and two chairs.

COORPAROO

Two seater lounge, recliner and rocker, cream leather, 6 yrs old.

Item no. TP003376687



Price: $350 Ad exp. 9 July 2013
Call Marie, 0411 000 111

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Hints for cutting costs

If you can't afford lots of furniture straight away, consider these ideas:

- cover milk crates with cloths and use them as side tables
- buy cushions instead of expensive lounge suites
- put up posters instead of buying paintings
- check out garage sales for cheap furniture and household items
- check bargain stores for cheap items such as bath mats, towels and cleaning products.

Activities

1 Why is cost such an important consideration when making a list of things you need to buy for your new home?

2 Ben and Matthew decided to move into an unfurnished apartment. Between them they had $750 saved. Based on the costs table on the previous page, what items do you think they should buy? What items would they be able to do without? How much would they have to pay?

3 Anna and Stephanie had saved over $4000 between them. They also had no furniture. Based on the costs table above, what items do you think they should buy?

4 Study the two advertisements for lounge suites on the previous page and answer the following questions:

- ***a*** What is the difference between the two suites?
- ***b*** What is the difference in price?
- ***c*** What factors could influence the price in each case?
- ***d*** What information do the two advertisements provide?
- ***e*** Which lounge suite would you choose, based on the information above? Give reasons.
- ***f*** How would you proceed with the purchase?
- ***g*** What is meant by 'ad exp. 15 July 2013'?

5 What are the advantages of a sofa bed lounge?

6 How might you avoid having to pay for a washing machine?

7 Which items listed in the costs table on the previous page do you believe to be absolutely essential?

8 Of the hints for cutting costs, which ones do you think are the most useful? Why?

9 What other hints can you think of to save money when moving into a new place?

Individually, or in groups, access the websites of eBay and the Trading Post and check the range of prices for each of the basic items mentioned in the costs table on the previous page. Make your own table of prices. Add any other items you believe should be included.

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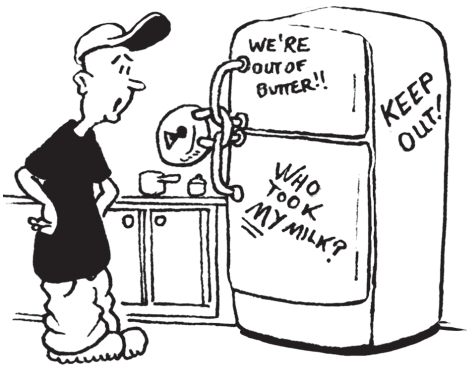
15 Share houses

Housemates



We are all different, so when choosing a housemate we need to be aware of the sort of person, or people we can live with. Differences in cultural, religious, social or political backgrounds can sometimes cause conflict. Differences can also exist between smokers and non-smokers, people who like their space tidy and people who don't mind a bit of mess, meat eaters and vegetarians, morning people and night people, outgoing and shy people and pet lovers and pet haters.

It may be a good idea to try and get to know the people you are sharing with before committing yourself. It is also important that everyone tries to be understanding and considerate of other people's beliefs and cultures.

Housemates and conflict

Read the following case studies to discover the kinds of problems people can have in share accommodation situations.

Mia

I am currently living with a female housemate who pretty much does what she likes. She works at the local pub and comes home around 7 or 8 in the morning. When she gets home she's incredibly noisy. This wouldn't be a problem normally, but I'm doing shift work and I can't sleep with all the noise she makes. Things have gone missing from my room, too – I think she might be stealing from me.

Daniel

I moved into a house with two other students and at first, all was well. After about three months a new girl moved in. As soon as she arrived she started cleaning and rearranging everything. She would clean practically every day. At first we didn't mind too much – at least the house was clean – but then things started getting worse. She told us we shouldn't use our dishwasher because it was dirty, so we had to wash everything by hand. She would leave a mess and then criticise others. It got to the point where she was constantly complaining and we were basically ignoring her. We are relatively clean, but I don't see the need to clean every single day.

Nick

I had a really bad experience once. I moved into a house with two girls under a joint tenancy. They were an absolute nightmare to live with and wouldn't pay any bills so I gave up after two months and moved out. However, the tenant who replaced me cleared out before signing the contract that the landlord had sent him. It turned out that both girls hadn't paid any rent since we moved in. It had been four months, but I wasn't aware until the landlord decided to throw them out. Because my name was left on the joint tenancy I've been dragged into the whole mess and am now being pursued for the rent they didn't pay.

Serap

I moved into a share house early last year with a few other people. Everything was fine until we realised one housemate didn't know how to use a bar of soap or a washing machine. He smelt terrible! We tried to explain why it was a good idea to shower daily, and why you had to actually clean the kitchen, not just wave a damp cloth over it. We went to the landlord, but he didn't want to get involved in personal disputes between tenants.

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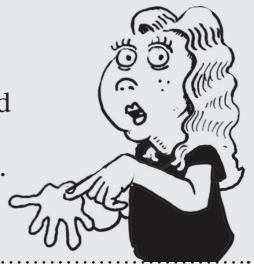
Natalie

I moved into a share house near my university that was occupied by a really shy guy. He seemed fine and helped me carry everything when I first moved in. Things seemed very normal – until my boyfriend came over one night. After he left, my flatmate said he wanted to have a 'chat'. He told me he had wanted a flatmate who was single. He thought that once we had spent some time together, we could have a romantic relationship. It was very awkward – I had to move out.



Household organisation

Moving in with other people can be a great experience, but living with people can be tricky. To avoid conflict, it can help to make decisions about how you want to run things. Agreeing on the details up front can keep them from becoming big issues down the track.

- cleaning the house (How will you divide up the jobs? How often do they need to be done?)
- washing the dishes (Will everyone wash their own dishes, or will you take it in turns?)
- preparing the meals (Will you each cook separate meals or will you take it in turns to cook for everyone? Will you share food or buy your own?)
- paying the bills (Who is in charge of the bills? How will they be split?)
- use of communal spaces/things, such as living areas, TV etc. (Will you have a timetable, or just consult one another?)

Activities

1 Explain the importance of household organisation in a share situation.

2 Study the list of potential issues above and rearrange them in order of importance in your view. Explain the reason for your first choice.

3 Write a sentence describing the type of housemate you would like to live with.

4 Read the case studies illustrating some of the issues that can arise in share houses.

- ***a*** What was Mia's problem with her housemate?
- ***b*** How would you advise Mia to handle her situation?
- ***c*** Do you think Daniel was justified in his criticism of his housemate? Why/why not?
- ***d*** If you were Daniel what would you say to the housemate?
- ***e*** Imagine you are Daniel's housemate. What would be your response to him?
- ***f*** What was Serap's objection to her new housemate?
- ***g*** If you were Serap, what would you say to your housemate?
- ***h*** What options might be available to Serap to resolve the conflict in their house?
- ***i*** What problem did Natalie face when she moved into her flat?
- ***j*** How did Natalie resolve the problem?
- ***k*** What was the arrangement when Nick first moved in to a shared house?
- ***l*** How did this arrangement backfire on Nick?
- ***m*** What do you think Nick's options were in resolving his position?

5 Do the case studies have anything in common? How might house rules prevent these problems from occurring?

Working in groups or pairs, role play a conversation between the housemates in one of the case studies. See if you're able to find a way to resolve the conflict in the house.

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16 The household budget

Managing the household's finances is an important aspect of living in shared premises. Making a budget is an effective way to keep things under control.

Definition: A budget is a plan outlining your expected income, spending and savings patterns over a period of time.

The key to managing a household budget is working out:

- household income – money coming in
- household expenses – money going out
- priorities – which expenses do you have to pay, and which can you avoid.

Establishing priorities

There are some things you have to pay for on a regular basis. These include food, rent, electricity and telephone bills. There are other items which may also need to be allowed for. These can include medical expenses, train fares and car or bicycle repairs. Then there are luxury items such as new electronic gadgets, overseas holidays or weekends away. If you can manage the essential items and allow for occasional added expenses it may also be possible to indulge in some luxuries from time to time. If you are having problems paying for the essentials, however, it is the luxury items that need to be cut first.

Sharing expenses

Some expenses, such as rent and electricity, may be shared with your housemates, while others, such as mobile phones, will be separate. How landline costs are shared will depend on whether one housemate makes more calls to mobile or long distance numbers. You may need to devise a system of either recording telephone calls or monitoring the bill when it comes in to ensure costs are split fairly.

Some share houses set up a combined fund or 'kitty' to manage shared expenses. Each housemate puts in an agreed amount of money each week to cover expenses. The kitty might be used to pay for rent and electricity, and sometimes also covers food and other household items such as dishcloths, tea towels and toilet paper. In other share houses people prefer to buy their own food, particularly if some housemates eat out a lot while others prefer to stay at home. However, this can lead to difficulties when it comes to keeping food separate, and remembering what belongs to each person.

Managing bills

Managing bills sometimes requires a bit of planning. Most bills arrive regularly – they are usually issued either monthly or quarterly. It is a good idea to make a note of when you expect bills to arrive, and when they will need to be paid. This will help you to ensure that you have enough money set aside to pay bills when they arrive.

It is important to stay on top of your expenses. Failure to pay the rent on time can lead to disputes with the landlord or agent and can have serious consequences. If you do run into trouble with any of your accounts, it is a good idea to contact the company first to see what arrangements you can make. Many companies will be willing to let you pay in instalments to help you get on top of your debts.

Creating a budget

A good way to plan for your expenses is to draw up a simple budget. Using two columns, write down how much you earn each week (or fortnight or month) in the left-hand column, and how much you spend on essentials on the right-hand column. The money that is left over after you subtract your expenses from your income represents your savings. This money can be set aside for unforeseen expenses, or perhaps spent on luxuries.

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Here is a sample fortnightly budget for Jake and Jim, based on their combined income of $800 per fortnight and their combined expenses.

Household budget for Jake and Jim			
Income – per fortnight		**Expenses – per fortnight**	
Wages	$800	Rent	$200
		Electricity	$50
		Food	$100
		Train fares	$60
		Lunches	$40
		Telephone	$150
Total income	**$800**	**Total expenses**	**$600**
		Savings for fortnight	**$200**

Activities

1 What is a budget? Why is it important in managing finances?

2 Explain the difference between essential and non-essential items.

3 Are luxury items the same as non-essential items? Explain.

4 What types of expenses are most likely to be shared when two or more people are renting?

5 Why might it be better to separate expenses such as telephone charges rather than share them?

6 Why should the rent be always paid on time? What could happen if you fall behind in your rent?

7 Why might it be a good idea to know when bills will arrive and when payment will be due? What could happen if you don't plan ahead in this way?

8 What should you do if you are having trouble paying a bill?

9 What might be the consequences of being unable to pay bills over a long period of time?

10 Study the sample budget for Jake and Jim above.

- ***a*** What were their combined wages?
- ***b*** How much was the rent? What percentage was this of their total income? How might this figure be useful?
- ***c*** Check the expenses column and identify which items could be reduced. Explain how.
- ***d*** What was the expected savings figure for their budget? How might this be used?

Working in groups, construct another sample budget. You may wish to include additional items and to alter the figures to reflect current prices and costs.

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17 Repairs and maintenance issues

There can sometimes be conflict between tenants and their landlords or agents over repairs and maintenance. The following conversations demonstrate the kinds of conflict that can take place regarding this issue.

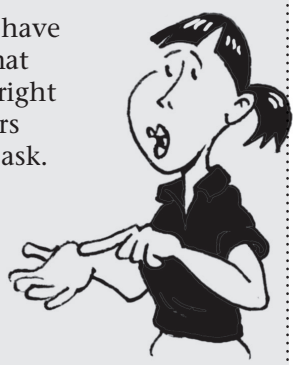
Melissa (tenant): Mr Johnson, I'm not happy. Those repairs I requested three weeks ago still have not been done. This is the third time I have had to ring you – I'd like to know what's going on.

Mr Johnson (agent): I have been in contact with the landlord and he says that the repairs you've requested are not urgent.

Melissa: I disagree. The leaking tap in the kitchen is wasting a huge amount of water, and the broken light fittings in the lounge room are inconvenient, not to mention dangerous.

Mr Johnson: I think you are being a bit fussy, Melissa.

Melissa: As a tenant I have rights, and that includes the right to have repairs done when I ask. I want these things fixed immediately or I will take further action.



Mr Johnson: Making threats won't help the situation, Melissa.

Melissa decides to ring her state consumer affairs department to seek some clarification. She talks to Jo, a consumer affairs public relations officer.

Melissa: Hi Jo, my name is Melissa. I've just had an argument with my agent about some repairs to my apartment. I believe the repairs are urgent but my landlord doesn't agree, and won't fix them.

Jo: Okay Melissa, what kind of repairs are we talking about?

Melissa: There are broken light fittings in the lounge room, and a leaking tap in the kitchen. Surely these things qualify as urgent repairs?

Jo: Urgent repairs usually involve safety issues, things like dangerous electrical faults, gas leaks, and blocked or broken toilets. Appliances or fittings that are not working properly would definitely be classed as urgent. Leaking taps where a substantial amount of water is being wasted can also be classed as urgent.

Melissa: Thanks for that. I will contact the agent again to tell them what you have said. If that doesn't work, what should I do?

Jo: If they still won't agree to the repairs there is an administrative tribunal you can apply to. See how you go.

Urgent repairs

It is important to distinguish between urgent and non-urgent repairs. Repairs are generally the landlord's responsibility. If the tenant or resident caused the damage, however, the landlord can ask them to arrange or pay for repairs. Landlords or their agents also have a responsibility to respond to repair requests promptly. Tenants must continue paying rent when they are waiting for repairs to be done.

Requests for urgent repairs

As a tenant there are a number of steps you should take if you need an urgent repair:

- Contact the landlord or agent about the problem, and clearly state that the repair is urgent. It's best to keep all your communication in writing, so you have a record of the discussions that have taken place. In most states, if the landlord or agent doesn't arrange for the repair to be done, you can arrange this yourself, so long as it doesn't cost more than $1000.

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- You would then need to contact the landlord asking to be reimbursed for the repair. The landlord usually has to pay you within 14 days.
- If the landlord refuses to pay you, or if the repairs will cost more than $1000, you can apply to the administrative tribunal in your state, which will grant you a hearing. The tribunal can order the landlord to arrange the repairs.

Non-urgent repairs

If the repairs are not urgent, you still need to contact the landlord or agent in writing to request the repair. If the repairs aren't carried out within a reasonable time (this depends on the nature of the repairs), you can contact the administrative tribunal in your state. In most cases you have 60 days to make your application. In the meantime, you must continue paying rent until the matter is sorted out.

Tribunals

There are various state tribunals whose task is to resolve disputes between tenants and landlords, each with different names.

State tribunals

Australian Capital Territory Residential Tenancies Tribunal

New South Wales Consumer, Trader & Tenancy Tribunal

Northern Territory Northern Territory Department of Justice

Queensland Residential Tenancies Authority

South Australia Residential Tenancies Tribunal

Tasmania Residential Tenancy Commissioner

Victoria Victorian Civil and Administrative Tribunal

Western Australia Department of Consumer and Employment Protection

Activities

1 Why do you think conflict arises between landlords and tenants over repairs and maintenance issues?

2 Why is it important to distinguish between urgent repairs and non-urgent repairs?

3 Give three examples of urgent repairs and explain why you believe they are urgent.

4 As a tenant, how would you go about requesting that urgent repairs be carried out in the premises you are renting?

Imagine you are renting a house and you need an urgent repair done. Write a letter to your landlord requesting the repair. What information do you need to include in the letter? What sort of tone do you think your letter should have? Swap letters with someone else and write a response to their request.

5 What options do you have if the landlord refuses to carry out the repairs?

6 Read the telephone conversation between Melissa and her agent, Mr Johnson.

- ***a*** What was Melissa's problem?
- ***b*** What was the agent's response to Melissa's phone call?
- ***c*** How would you rate the agent's attitude in this phone conversation? What about Melissa's attitude?
- ***d*** What would you suggest that Melissa could have done differently?
- ***e*** If Melissa lived in New South Wales, what authority could she approach?

7 Read the telephone conversation between Melissa and Jo, the consumer affairs officer.

- ***a*** What did Melissa ask Jo? Why?
- ***b*** What did Jo tell Melissa?
- ***c*** How would you describe their conversation, in terms of courtesy?

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18 The neighbourhood

Every neighbourhood is different. Whenever you move into a new area, there will be things you need to know and things you need to consider in order to ensure you get along with your neighbours and are a respectful member of the community.

Know your neighbourhood

The following information can help you to settle into your new neighbourhood. Find out about:

- **rubbish collection** – which day of the week the rubbish is collected, whether there are special bins for recycling and garden waste
- **public transport** – where is the nearest bus stop and train station? When do the buses and trains arrive?
- **shops and facilities** – where is the nearest supermarket, petrol station, shopping centre, post office, bank, park, library, swimming pool, gym, etc.
- **neighbours** – get to know the people living nearby. Be considerate of any needs or concerns they may have.

Being a considerate neighbour

There are many things you can do to ensure that you are a good neighbour. It is important to treat your neighbours with respect and consider their needs as well as your own when going about your day-to-day lives.

Privacy

Many homes are built very close together, and in these circumstances it is particularly important to remember that you are entitled to privacy in your home, and so are your neighbours. It is not considerate to look over fences or in windows, or to eavesdrop on your neighbours' conversations. Also consider your own conversations – it is best to discuss private matters indoors, where the neighbours can't hear you.

Noise

There is a federal government organisation which aims to control unwanted noise and the impact it has on the community. The website is at www.noisewatch.org.au. You may wish to make a complaint about unnecessary noise in your neighbourhood, or you could be the subject of a complaint about noise. Many people can be affected by noise in a neighbourhood. It is important to be considerate of your neighbours, particularly if making a lot of noise late at night. It is considerate to warn your neighbours if you are planning a loud party or event.

Pets

It is important to be aware of any council laws regarding keeping pets in your area. Some councils have restrictions such as which breeds of animals can be kept as pets, and curfews for cats. It is also important to be aware of how your pet affects your neighbours – issues such as noise, smell and damage to property can all be concerns.

Garden maintenance

As a member of the community, it can be considerate to ensure that your property is maintained to a certain standard. Keeping gardens tidy, trees trimmed and lawns mown are all ways of ensuring that your property looks good and is making a positive contribution to the neighbourhood.

Resolving disputes

If you have an issue with your neighbour, the best place to start is to talk to them about it. Find a time to discuss the matter with them calmly. Clearly outline the reasons for your concern, and try to sound objective, rather than critical. If each person considers the other person's viewpoint calmly, it will usually be possible to reach an understanding. If you are unable to resolve your dispute in this way, most states have a dispute resolution service, such as the Dispute Settlement Centre of Victoria, or the Dispute Resolution Centre in Queensland.

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Getting involved in the community

Getting involved in your local community has many benefits. It can be healthy and enjoyable to interact with other people in your local area, and the sense of satisfaction of contributing to your community should not be underestimated. By participating in community activities you also learn skills which you can apply in later years.

Two common ways that people engage with their local community are:

- doing volunteer work, such as working with a local charity or council organisation
- joining a club, such as a sporting club, music or craft club.

Community support

Local councils provide various forms of support for members of the community. This support can include:

- help for disabled or elderly residents
- neighbourhood watch
- childcare
- clubs and sporting groups
- housing and emergency accommodation.

If you are in need of any help, whether it is emotional, physical or financial, your local council could be a good place to start. Similarly, if you would like to offer help to others in your community, volunteering for one of these organisations could be a great way to make a contribution.

Activities

1 Why is getting to know about rubbish collection important when you first move into a new neighbourhood? How might recycling be an issue in this?

2 Why would you need to become familiar with public transport timetables?

3 Make a list of the shops and other facilities you would be most likely to visit in a new neighbourhood. Which two would you expect to visit the most often and why?

4 Jack and Jane loved to lie out in their backyard and sunbake. Fred, the next door neighbour would often peer at them over the fence. Is this a privacy issue? What is your view? What could Jack and Jane do about it?

5 Jack and Jane liked to hold loud parties every Saturday night, going well into the early hours of Sunday morning. The next door neighbours had had enough and one night they called the police. Who do you think is in the wrong? What action do you think the neighbours should have taken?

6 In Chris and Maya's street, everyone keeps their lawns mown and gardens tidy at all times. Chris and Maya are both very busy, however, and don't have time to maintain their garden. How do you think their neighbours feel about this? What could Chris and Maya do to resolve the issue?

7 What benefits do you see in getting involved in the local community? Give an example of a way you think you could contribute.

Write a guide to living in your local community. Include information regarding rubbish collection, public transport and local shops. Research your local council and make a list of the services available in your area.

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19 Health issues

Moving out isn't just about finding a new place to live. There will be other issues that you may not have had to consider until now. Taking care of your health is a big part of life.

Finding a GP

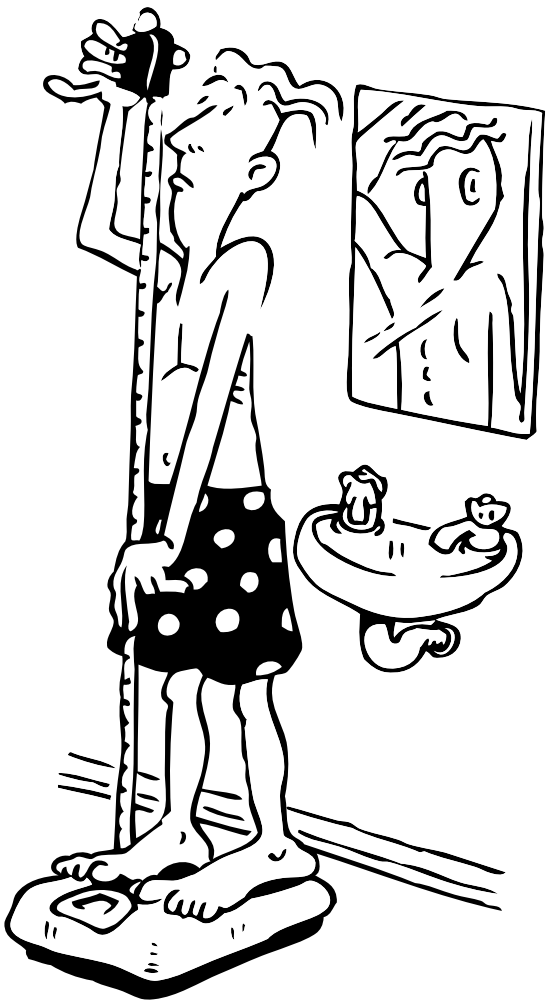
When you move into a new neighbourhood it may be necessary to register as a patient with a local doctor or GP (General Practitioner). Some medical practices have several doctors based in one medical centre. This means that you will generally have access to one of the doctors at all times, which can make it easier to get an appointment when you need one. If changing doctors, you may need to arrange to have your medical records transferred from your previous doctor. Some doctors will charge a small administration fee for doing this.

Medicare

Medicare is Australia's universal health care system. It provides all Australians with access to free or low-cost medical and hospital care. All Australian citizens can register with Medicare by filling in an enrolment form and being issued with a Medicare card. This card can then be presented at any Medicare branch to receive a refund on medical expenses. All you need is the doctor's bill and your Medicare card. Alternatively, you can also claim your refund electronically, so the money is paid directly into your bank account. If your doctor bulk-bills, then you can simply sign a form acknowledging treatment and no payment is required.

Health insurance

There are some medical services that Medicare does not cover. These include things like dental treatment, optical services and private hospital visits. Many people choose to take out private health insurance to help cover additional medical costs. There are several companies which offer private health cover (which gives you your own choice of doctor and access to a private hospital). Examples include Medibank Private, HCF and NIB. Some companies also offer extra levels of cover, for things like dental and optical care, for an additional fee.



Ambulance

You may also choose to join an ambulance fund. This means that if you ever need an ambulance in an emergency, you don't have to pay. Ambulance rides can cost hundreds of dollars, whereas the yearly fee to join an ambulance fund is usually only around $70 per year. Ambulance costs are not covered by Medicare.

Dental services

Regular dental check-ups can help prevent major dental issues from occurring. It's a good idea to find a dentist in your area. Dental services are not covered by Medicare, but if you have a health care or concession card you may be eligible for public dental treatment, which is a lot more affordable. Some private health insurance funds also offer coverage for dental care.

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Mental health

If you are struggling to cope and need some support, there are many options available. Your GP will be able to refer you to a counsellor. Alternatively, organisations such as Beyond Blue, headspace and Lifeline can provide help.

Sexual health

As well as your GP, there are several other places you can go for sexual health services. Your local Family Planning Centre or Sexual Health Centre will offer confidential advice and treatment, and many places will allow you to remain anonymous.

University health services

Most universities will offer information and treatment to students, including general health services, counselling, sexual health advice, travel advice and vaccinations. Most of these services are bulk billed.

Health and fitness

Although it is important to be covered for any medical problems that might occur, it is also important to look after your health, as this can prevent problems from occurring in the first place. Exercising regularly and eating a balanced diet will help you to stay fit and healthy. People who don't exercise and who don't eat a healthy diet run the risk of becoming unwell, overweight or even obese. Obesity is most commonly measured using the Body Mass Index (BMI), which measures a person's weight-to-height ratio.

Activities

1. Why might you need to register with a new GP if you move to a new area?
2. What is Medicare? How does it work?
3. Why is it important to look after your health?
4. What is the purpose of private health insurance? In your opinion, is it worthwhile? Give reasons to support your answer.
5. Why is it important to eat a balanced diet? What do you think might happen if you don't do this?
6. Is dental treatment covered by Medicare?
7. If you feel unhappy or are struggling to cope, where should you go?
8. What would you visit a Family Planning Centre for?

Research two different private health insurance providers and the costs of basic hospital cover. Compare the cost of basic cover with the cost of extras cover. Are the extras that are covered the same in each case? Which do you think is better value?

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20 Voting

The right to vote is an important aspect of living in a democracy. In Australia, voting is compulsory and all people over the age of 18 are required to vote in all elections, whether for federal, state or local government. Failure to vote may result in a fine.

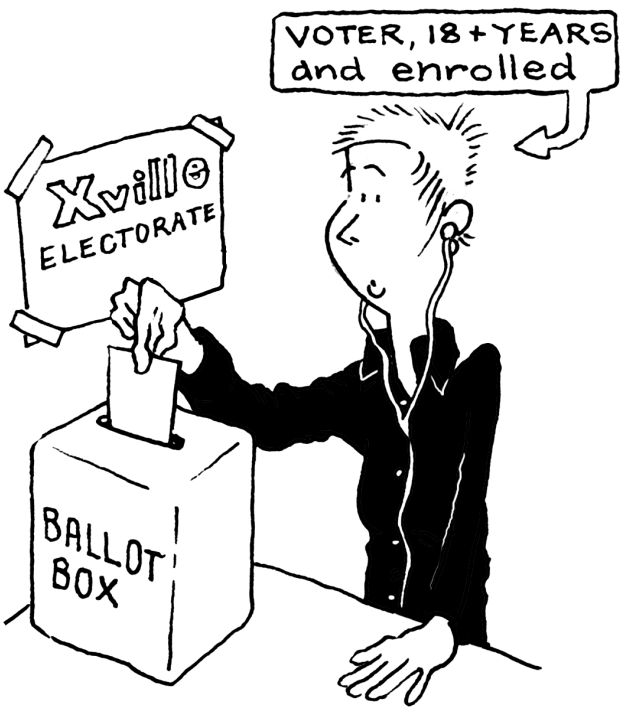
In order to take part in elections, you must be enrolled in your current electorate. This is determined by where you live. To enrol to vote, you must complete an enrolment application form, which you can obtain from any post office or from the Australian Electoral Commission (AEC) website at www.aec.gov.au.

To be eligible to be listed on the electoral roll, you must:

- be 18 years of age or older
- have lived at your current address for at least a month
- be an Australian citizen (either born in Australia or granted Australian citizenship).

After you have been placed on the electoral roll you will receive a card indicating which electorate you are enrolled in. If you move after you have enrolled, you must notify the AEC of your change of address.

Getting involved in politics



While elections are held only every three or four years, there are other ways of participating in a democracy. They can include:

- forming pressure groups to lobby the government about a particular issue
- attending public meetings, demonstrations or protests
- joining a club
- writing letters to the editors of newspapers
- writing letters to local members of parliament
- making an appointment for a personal interview with a member of parliament
- approaching radio or television journalists or ringing a radio station on talkback radio
- expressing our opinions in public places
- joining a political party.

Political parties

Australia's main political parties are:

Australian Greens Party	**www.greens.org.au**
Australian Labor Party	**www.alp.org.au**
Liberal Party of Australia	**www.liberal.org.au**
National Party	**www.nationals.org.au**

You can find out more about their policies and goals from their websites, which are constantly being updated. Information about the political parties is also regularly broadcast on radio and television and reported in national newspapers.

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Glossary of important terms

Electoral roll	A document that lists all enrolled voters
Electorate	A district consisting of people entitled to vote for a member of parliament
General election	An election held to decide the government of the whole country or state
By election	An election held just for one particular electorate, for example after the death or retirement of that electorate's member of parliament
Referendum	A vote by the people on a particular question
Polling place	A place where people go to record their vote in an election
Informal vote	A vote which is not counted because the ballot paper is incorrectly filled in
Scrutineers	People who oversee the counting of votes after an election
MP	Member of Parliament, either federal or state
House of Representatives	The lower house of federal parliament
Senate	The upper house of federal parliament
Legislative Assembly	The lower house of state parliament
Legislative Council	The upper house of state parliament
Governor-General	The Queen's representative in Australia
Prime Minister	The leader of the federal government
Premier	The leader of the state government
Mayor	The leader or spokesperson of a local council
Constitution	A list of basic rules and principles used to govern the country.

Activities

1 What are the three main requirements to be able to vote in an election in Australia?

2 Match the following terms with their definitions below:

Terms	***Definitions***
Referendum	***a*** The upper house of federal parliament
By election	***b*** The leader or spokesperson of a local council
Premier	***c*** The Queen's representative in Australia
Polling place	***d*** A vote by the people on a particular question
Prime Minister	***e*** An election held to decide the government of the whole country or state
General election	***f*** A place where people go to record their vote in an election
Governor-General	***g*** The leader of the federal government
Scrutineers	***h*** People who oversee the counting of votes after an election
Mayor	***i*** An election held just for one particular electorate
Senate	***j*** The leader of the state government

3 Voting in Australia is compulsory. True or false?

4 Make a list of the different ways you can be involved in politics. Which ones appeal to you most, and why?

5 What are the dangers associated with getting involved in protests and demonstrations?

6 Write a letter to your local member of state parliament about an issue that concerns you, such as a public transport, education or police matter. Indicate what you are unhappy about and what action you are suggesting.

Imagine you are running for local government. Make a list of the issues that you think matter most to voters. What would your main policies be, and how would you communicate these to voters?

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21 Moving out crossword

Clues

Across

2 A vote by the people on a particular question put to them.

4 A type of house that shares a common wall with a neighbour.

5 Australia's universal health care system

7 A plan of expected income and expenses for a period

8 The neighbours might complain about this if you have a party late at night.

9 A person who wishes to rent a property.

10 Internet Service Provider (acronym)

12 Rental contract between landlord and tenant

13 Unit of information in a computer

17 Person who shares accommodation with you

19 Turning 18 years of age, also known as achieving your ...

20 Accessing material from the internet: _____ing

22 Accommodation providing private rooms

23 High-speed internet service

24 Energy which does not deplete limited resources.

Down

1 Kilowatt hours (acronym)

2 Money paid by tenant to lease premises

3 District of people entitled to vote

6 A list of rules and principles used to govern a country

11 When people are extremely overweight

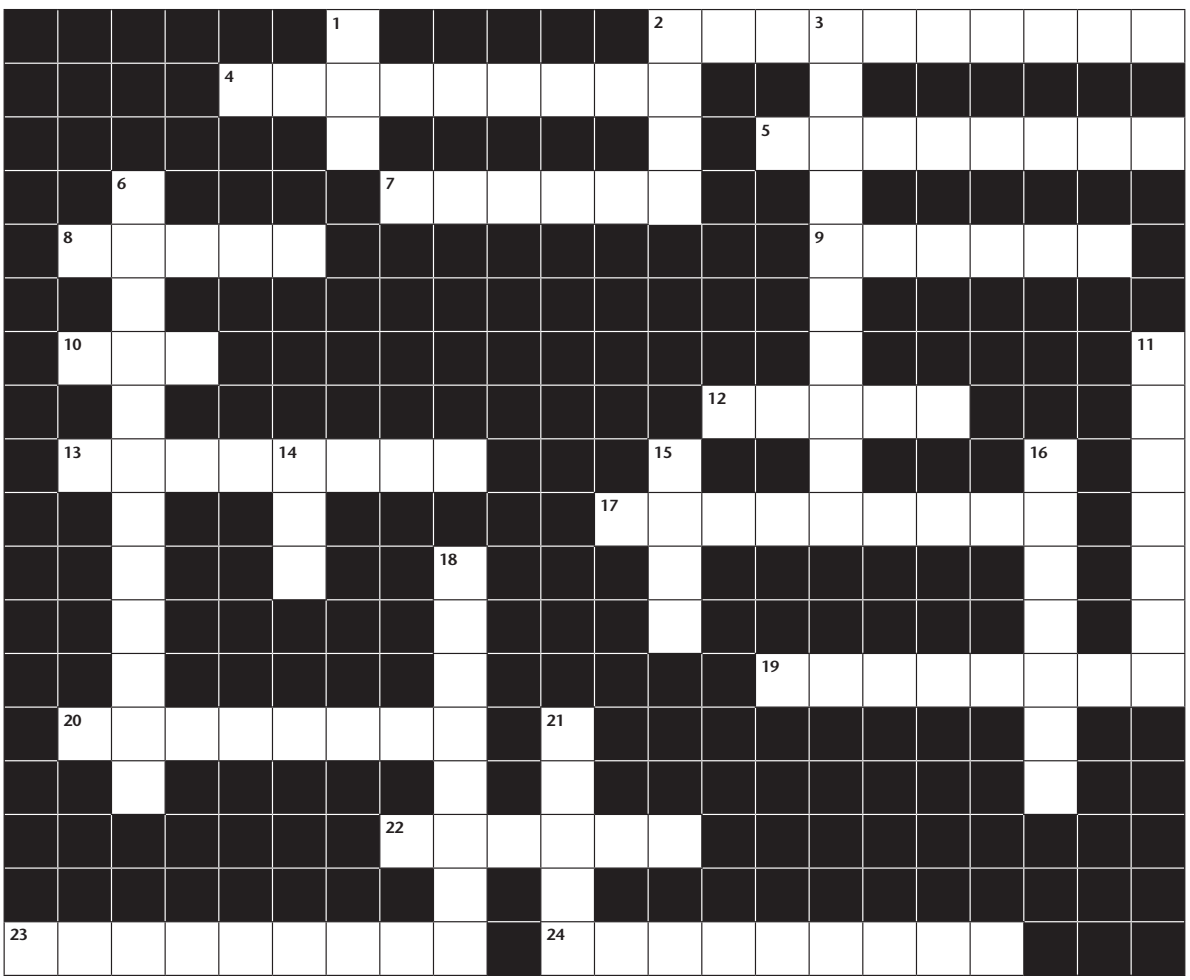
14 Body Mass Index (acronym)

15 Money paid in advance as security for lease

16 These are required when things in a property are broken.

18 Person who owns a property and is prepared to let it

21 Instrument used to measure electricity use



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Selected answers

1 WHEN CAN I LEAVE HOME?

2 When you turn 18 years old. That is when you are legally an adult.
3 If your parents or carers agree, or if your safety and wellbeing are under threat.
4 Fear of the unknown, potential problems, loneliness, money worries.
5 Fear you're not ready, they will miss you, concern that you are not married, concern about other people living with you.
6 Answers may vary. Ben ignored the tips 'don't leave for the wrong reason' and 'don't act too hastily'.
7 Jessica may have advised Ben to wait a little longer, or try to resolve conflict with his parents.
8 Communication skills – both speaking and listening. Ability to understand other people's point of view.
9 Alicia needs to consider whether she can handle living away from home, and whether she really wants the job.
10 **a** Did Omar want to live away from home and branch out? Which university did he prefer?
b Would he move away and pursue his degree or would he consider a different university course?

2 MOVING OUT, MOVING BACK

1 Kipper is an acronym for Kids In Parents' Pockets Eroding Retirement Savings.
2 Boomerang refers to kids returning to their home after moving out.
3 It revealed that young Australians are staying at home more than ever before.
4 Overseas research indicated similar patterns of young people returning home.
5 To save money for entertainment or to invest.
6 You are introduced to other cultures and new friendships, ways of seeing things, being entertained, cooking etc.
7 Perks such as cable TV, faster internet, free drinks and food. It is possible to enjoy these perks while living independently, but you need to budget for them.
8 Human behaviour can be rich and interesting, and meeting new people is a way of exploring this.
9 Style cramping refers to the cringe that can come with spending too much time with your parents. Even if you get on with your parents you (and they) still need space to do your own thing.
10 The article encourages readers to consider the advantages of living away from home.

3 HOMELESSNESS

1 Emma's and Luke's stories are similar in that they both were forced to leave home due to unhappy or abusive circumstances. They differ in that with help, Luke overcame his difficulties, while Emma's life continued on a negative path.
3 Causes of homelessness can include domestic violence, family relationship breakdowns, drug and alcohol abuse.
4 Relative homelessness occurs where people stay in boarding houses or in emergency accommodation, while absolute homelessness means living on the streets or in improvised dwellings such as parks or deserted buildings.
5 Causes include family relationship breakdown, domestic violence, sexual, mental or emotional abuse, mental illness or disability, gambling, financial problems, drug and alcohol abuse, bereavement, overcrowding. Most common and reasons are a matter of student opinion.
6 Roughly 50 per cent
7 Homeless people can be male or female, old or young.
8 'Temporary accommodation' could refer to sleeping on the streets, in parks, caravans or abandoned buildings.
9 Department of Community Services in each state, Centrelink, organisations such as Kids Helpline or Lifeline.
10 Kids Helpline is an organisation designed to help kids in need. It will help young people who urgently need immediate housing and food.

4 DIFFERENT TYPES OF ACCOMMODATION

1 You need to be aware of all the options open to you before deciding.
2 Prices are important if you are on a tight budget. For example, full board or share accommodation would normally be cheaper than renting on your own.
3 More independent people may prefer to live alone, or with just one other person.
4 **a** boarding houses – houses offering a room and meals, run by a landlord.
b studios – small apartments with no separate bedroom but combined bedroom/living area.
c apartments – separate bedrooms, kitchen, bathroom and living area, often in multi-storey buildings.
d hostels – a type of shared accommodation with private bedrooms but shared cooking and washing facilities.
e Student residences – usually based on university or college premises and often furnished.
f Free accommodation – provided in exchange for work such as childcare, live-in housekeeping or other arrangements to work for board.
g Townhouses – houses that share common walls with a neighbour. Usually have a garden or terrace at ground level.
5 Protection is provided by the Residential Tenancies Act.
6 Generally cheaper and perhaps safer if others are there to help.
7 Different in terms of price, availability, type of premises (terrace house and apartment), type of tenants they want.
8 Jack appears very personable and confident, someone who likes socialising and having fun. Some might be happy to share with him, others not.

5 HOW DO I FIND A PLACE TO LIVE?

1 Proximity to place of work/study, and availability of public transport.
2 Cost of accommodation; travel costs.
3 Boarding house, shared accommodation, independent living in rented accommodation.
4 Options include visit local real estate agents, look online, check newspaper advertisements, check notice boards, word of mouth.
5 Yusuf probably decided too soon and should have checked other alternatives before making a decision.
6 Suggestions may include: tell Tora to find somewhere else to live; try to resolve the problems with her housemates.
7 ac: air conditioning; lug: lock up garage; ens: ensuite bathroom; dbl gar: double garage; furn: furnished; ldry: laundry; lng: lounge; bir: built-in robes; wi pant: walk in pantry; mod: modern.

6 CHOOSING YOUR ACCOMMODATION

1 The illustration is trying to show the many different factors to be considered in choosing a place to live.
2 People have different personalities – some like being alone, other are always seeking company. Advantages and disadvantages depend on who you are and the particular circumstances.
3 Cost is important if you are on a tight budget – it is important to ensure you can afford the cost of your chosen accommodation.
8 Safety and security are very important and could affect location choice.

7 WHAT IS A LEASE?

1 **a** bond; **b** tenant; **c** landlord; **d** lease; **e** rent; **f** premises.
2 True
3 Landlord (or their agent) and tenant
4 Rent to be paid, date payment is due and rental conditions.
5 You are better protected in law if you have the agreement in writing, in case something goes wrong.
6 Landlord and tenant need to agree on things like standards of cleanliness, repairs, responsibilities such as lawns, garden etc.
8 The office or Department of Fair Trading (in each state) will provide guidelines and advice for tenants.

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8 THE BOND AND THE RENT

1 Rent money is what the tenant pays the landlord regularly for leasing the premises; bond money is paid in advance as security against possible damage to the property that needs to be repaired at the end of the lease.

2 At the end of the tenancy the bond money will be returned to the tenant, in full, unless there is damage to the property that needs to be repaired.

3 **a** True; **b** True; **c** False; **d** False; **e** False

4 It is always better to try to resolve a problem with the people immediately involved rather than going to a third party.

5 It is not legally acceptable to withhold rent on the basis of repairs not done. This should be dealt with as a separate issue.

6 Jodie would be advised to point out that rent cannot be increased without giving advance notice (60 days), and that is her legal right.

9 THE CONDITION REPORT

1 A condition report is a description of the premises, including fixtures and fittings, designed to serve as a statement of the condition of a premises prior to a tenant moving in.

2 The landlord or landlord's agent generally prepares the report. The report is checked by the tenant before both parties sign off on it.

3 The tenant needs to check details closely to prevent disputes about damage to the property at the end of the tenancy.

4 The landlord has the right to claim some or all of the bond money to cover the cost of repairs to the property or loss of items.

5 **a** Dirty and badly stained carpet.
b The landlord dismissed the problem and did not have the carpet cleaned.
c The landlord believed the tenants had damaged the carpet and refused to return the bond money.
d Yes, if it was recorded on the condition report.
e If they had damaged the carpet themselves or had worsened the damage through their own carelessness.

6 **a** Yes, because he did not examine the condition report closely enough and report the damage.
b No, as he did not report the damage.
c He should have taken the condition report seriously and noted the damage.
d The agent or landlord would be expected to conclude that the damage was caused by the tenant.

7 **a** Sally carefully checked the condition report and pointed out the damage.
b You would point out that you had recorded the faults on the condition report at the beginning of the tenancy and that nothing was done to repair them. You would therefore request that bond money be paid as is your legal right.

10 CONNECTING SERVICES

1 The services you would need would include electricity, gas, water and telephone. Some of these services may not be included in the rent because some people make heavier use of them than others and landlords prefer to let the tenant pay for usage.

2 Energy involves electricity and gas to power or heat domestic appliances and buildings.

3 Renewable energy is energy produced from renewable sources, such as solar, wind, geothermal, hydro and tidal power.

4 Australia has abundant supplies of coal and therefore it is cheaper to produce electricity with it. Renewable energy is more expensive because of initial costs to establish it, as well as the fact that some sources of renewable energy do not produce power all the time.

5 Energy providers are companies that supply power to consumers. Examples include Energy Australia, Integral Energy, AGL, Australian Power and Gas, Jackgreen, Origin Energy, Powerdirect and TRU Energy.

6 **a** Quarterly (every three months). The bill states 'Quarterly electricity account'.
b $439.50, payable 1 November 2013.
c It is calculated with a meter, in kWh or kilowatts per hour.
d It helps the consumer to monitor usage and perhaps save on power.

7 By phone (Bpay, debit or credit card), in person at Australia Post (cash, cheque, debit or credit card), by mail (cheque). Student opinion as to preferred method and reasons

8 Advantages: call rates are cheaper; puts you in touch easily. Disadvantages: Rental and connection fees; mobiles are more flexible and can be used outside home.

11 COMMUNICATION

1 Telecommunications (telephone and computers) have changed our way of life by becoming central to the way we communicate and how constantly connected we are to one another.

2 Landline telephone account involves a connection fee and a monthly rental fee but calls are cheaper. Mobile phones are more flexible and can be used outside the home, but calls can be much more expensive, depending on the contract.

3 Broadband is a high-speed internet service with a wide frequency range, allowing you to use the telephone and computer simultaneously. Dial-up is much slower, and does not allow this simultaneous use. Broadband is preferred by most because of its multiple use and faster speeds.

4 Downloading is extracting information from the computer, while uploading is sending material into the system via your computer. You can download a song and listen to it, but you can upload an email (by sending it to someone).

5 1000 in each example

6 File sharing is taking a file from one computer via the internet to another computer, such as music and video files. Sharing files protected by copyright is regarded as illegal as it affects the sale of music and videos by recognised companies.

7 **a** Internet Service Provider; **b** Asymmetric Digital Subscriber Line

8 Usage requirements, ability to change a plan, excess usage charges, data limits. They affect your monthly bills and flexibility of use.

9 Virus protection programs, keeping your password secret, being wary of emails from unknown sources, only opening attachments from senders you know and trust.

10 Toula and Omar had vastly different usage on the computer yet they shared initial establishment costs equally. This could be resolved by changing the way they split the monthly costs to reflect their relative usage.

11 In the first instance you should contact the company you are dealing with and give them the chance to resolve the problem. If that fails you can contact the Telecommunications Industry Ombudsman.

12 MOVING DAY

1 Moving is a big job and proper planning is essential to avoid underestimating the time required and avoid mistakes being made.

2 To ensure that you allow enough time and avoid a last-minute rush.

3 More or larger belongings might require a professional removalist, whereas fewer/smaller belongings could possibly be managed with a few car trips.

4 The assistance of a family member or friend with a larger vehicle or a truck, hiring a van which you drive yourself or getting a removalist with a large truck to do the work for you. Use of each would depend on your budget and the amount and size of your belongings.

5 Professional removalists can be expensive, so you need to assess what you have to spend and how much you have to move.

6 Bill's moving costs were the pizza he bought his friends to say thank you. Bill could have been more organised – if he had started packing sooner, he wouldn't have had to rush.

7 Friends and family probably wouldn't have been a good solution for Ally. She had a lot of furniture to fit into a smaller space, and professional removalists would be more experienced in transporting the items safely.

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13 WHAT DO I NEED TO BUY?

1 Items would probably include beds, table and chairs, refrigerator and basic kitchen equipment. Could also add a lounge, television and stereo.

4 They could agree to sell the lounge and share the money they get, or one could buy out the other's share at an agreed price.

6 **a** Categories refer to groups of items with similar features, such as electrical goods, cars, pets.
b Click on the 'search' button.
c The register button is for first time users to get onto the system, the sign-in button is for users who are already registered.
d Use the categories list and then perform a search.
e Appliances, tools and equipment, building materials, furniture, hardware.

14 WHAT WILL IT COST?

1 It is important to be aware of budget limitations to ensure you don't overspend and that your budget can stretch to cover all essential items.

2 With $750 they would probably buy two single beds ($200), a dining table and chairs ($200) and a refrigerator ($350). They could do without the other items until they could afford them.

3 They could buy everything listed in the table and still have money left over. They could also buy at the higher end of the price range.

4 **a** One is a 3-seater and armchair, the other is a 2-seater lounge, recliner and rocker.
b $100 difference
c The quantity of pieces, the condition of the furniture, and its age.
d They provide the location of the seller, the item number, the price and a sketch or photo with the description as well as the expiry date of the sale.
f You would make contact and make an offer in case the seller was willing to drop the price.
g On auction sites, there is a time limit on offers.

5 A sofa bed lounge is a lounge that folds out to become a bed.

6 By going to a laundromat, finding accommodation with laundry facilities on site, or by visiting family or friends and using their washing machine.

7 Bed, table and chairs and refrigerator are generally regarded as essential items.

15 SHARE HOUSES

1 It is important to agree on how key issues and tasks in shared living will be handled from the outset, to avoid misunderstandings or conflict.

4 **a** Mia was living with someone who comes home late and is a possible thief.
b Answers may include advising Mia to move out or ask her housemate to leave.
c Answers may vary. Daniel may have been justified in his criticism although the level of cleanliness in the house was probably a matter of debate.
f Serap objected to the poor hygiene standards of her housemate.
h Serap could have approached the housemate and explained diplomatically what the problem was. Another option might be to leave or ask the person in housemate to leave.
i Natalie's flatmate wanted a romantic relationship, not just a flatmate.
j Natalie resolved the problem by moving out.
k Nick signed a joint tenancy agreement with two girls.
l Nick's housemates didn't pay their rent. Even though he had moved out, his name was still on the lease so he was held responsible for the debt.
m Nick would need some legal advice because the debt he faced was not of his making.

5 All of the case studies emphasise the importance of communication and sensible household organisation to prevent disputes from arising.

16 THE HOUSEHOLD BUDGET

1 A budget is a plan of anticipated income and expenses. It is an important way of managing money sensibly by planning carefully and being prepared for unforeseen expenses.

2 Essential items are expenses that are necessary and cannot be avoided. Non-essential items are those which may only need to be allowed for occasionally and are not vital.

3 Luxury items are non-essential items with high prices that should only be bought if you have money left over after covering all essential costs.

4 Electricity charges, gas, water and landline. Also, possibly household cleaning expenses and food (depending on the arrangement).

5 Telephone expenses vary greatly with use and it is sometimes fairer to separate them out rather than share them.

6 Falling behind on rent payments can lead to disputes with the landlord or agent.

7 Planning for when payments will be due allows you to ensure that enough money is set aside to cover all costs. Lack of planning could result in being unable to pay some bills on time.

8 Approach the company and request more time to pay or negotiate to pay in instalments.

9 You may be forced to leave a place you are renting and seek help from family or friends.

10 **a** $800 per fortnight
b $200 per fortnight. 25%. This figure can help them understand how much of their income goes on rent and how much will be left to cover other costs.
c Telephone, lunches and food could all be reduced. Methods of doing this will vary.
d $200. It could be used to buy other items for their place or saved for luxuries or emergencies in the future.

17 REPAIRS AND MAINTENANCE ISSUES

1 Sometimes conflict arises when landlord and tenant fail to agree on what constitutes damage or whether something is in need of repair.

2 Urgent repairs could be associated with a safety, security or health issue, while non-urgent repairs could wait longer.

3 Answers could include blocked toilet, electrical faults in wiring or in appliances, water leakage.

4 First approach the landlord or agent in writing and ask for repairs to be done.

5 You can arrange for the repairs to be done (if less than $1000 worth) and send the landlord a written request for reimbursement. If they fail to reimburse the cost, or if the repairs are worth more than $1000, you can approach the administrative tribunal in your state to hear your application.

6 **a** Melissa found that there were urgent repairs needed on the place she was renting
b The agent did not consider the repairs she had requested to be urgent.
c The agent's attitude was dismissive and abrupt. Melissa was aggressive and confrontational.
d Melissa could perhaps have approached the agent more calmly and outlined clearly why she felt that the repairs were urgent. She should also have put her request in writing.
e the Consumer, Trader and Tenancy Tribunal

7 **a** Melissa asked about what constituted urgent repairs as she was in dispute with the agent about them.
b Jo explained that urgent repairs usually involved issues of safety and health.
c Both Melissa and Jo were courteous and Jo was supportive of Melissa's concerns.

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18 THE NEIGHBOURHOOD

1 Rubbish collection is a priority for health and hygiene reasons. Local councils generally have varying recycling systems and residents need to be aware of these.

2 Being familiar with public transport titles will help you to plan how to get to and from work, school or college, unless you plan to drive.

4 Privacy can be a big issue and people have a right to have their privacy respected. Jack and Jane could ask their neighbour not to do this or they could contact the police if the behaviour continues.

5 Jack and Jane were being inconsiderate in having the party, but the neighbours could have approached them first, before resorting to calling the police.

6 Chris and Maya's neighbours may feel that Chris and Maya are letting them down and may resent the unkempt appearance of their property. Chris and Maya could try to explain their position to their neighbours, or they could hire someone else to maintain the garden if they don't have time.

19 HEALTH ISSUES

1 It is a good idea to know who and where your local GP is and ensure that they have your details on file in case you ever need medical assistance.

2 Medicare is a government sponsored universal health care system. It works by people paying a levy with their taxes and the money being used to help people with the costs of medical or hospital care.

3 Looking after your health is the best way to prevent issues from arising.

4 Private health insurance is used to give people added protection so that they can receive more immediate medical and hospital care and other benefits not provided by Medicare, including choice of doctor, private hospital etc. Opinions will differ regarding whether it is worthwhile.

5 Eating a balanced diet ensures that your body receives the vitamins, nutrients and energy that it needs in order to stay healthy.

6 No, dental treatment is not covered by Medicare.

7 You could see a counsellor, or contact an organisation such as Beyond Blue, headspace or Lifeline.

8 For confidential advice or treatment regarding sexual health.

20 VOTING

1 You must be 18 years or older, be an Australian citizen and have lived at your current address for at least a month.

2 **a** Senate; **b** Mayor; **c** Governor-General; **d** Referendum; **e** General election; **f** Polling place; **g** Prime Minister; **h** Scrutineers; **i** By election; **j** Premier.

3 True

4 Attend public meetings, join a pressure group, write letters to politicians, ring radio or TV stations, join a political party.

5 If the protest or demonstration is not approved by the police, you may get arrested.

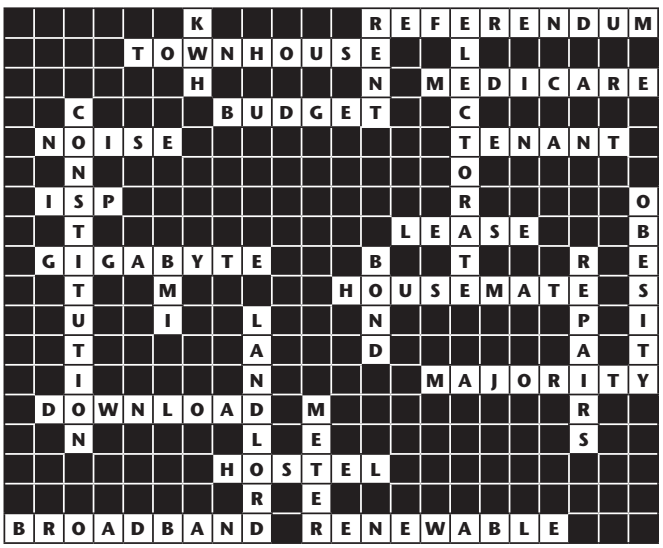
21 MOVING OUT CROSSWORD

Across

2 referendum **4** townhouse **5** medicare **7** budget **8** noise **9** tenant **10** ISP **12** lease **13** gigabyte **17** housemate **19** majority **20** download **22** hostel **23** broadband **24** renewable

Down

1 KWH **2** rent **3** electorate **6** constitution **11** obesity **14** BMI **15** bond **16** repairs **18** landlord **21** meter



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